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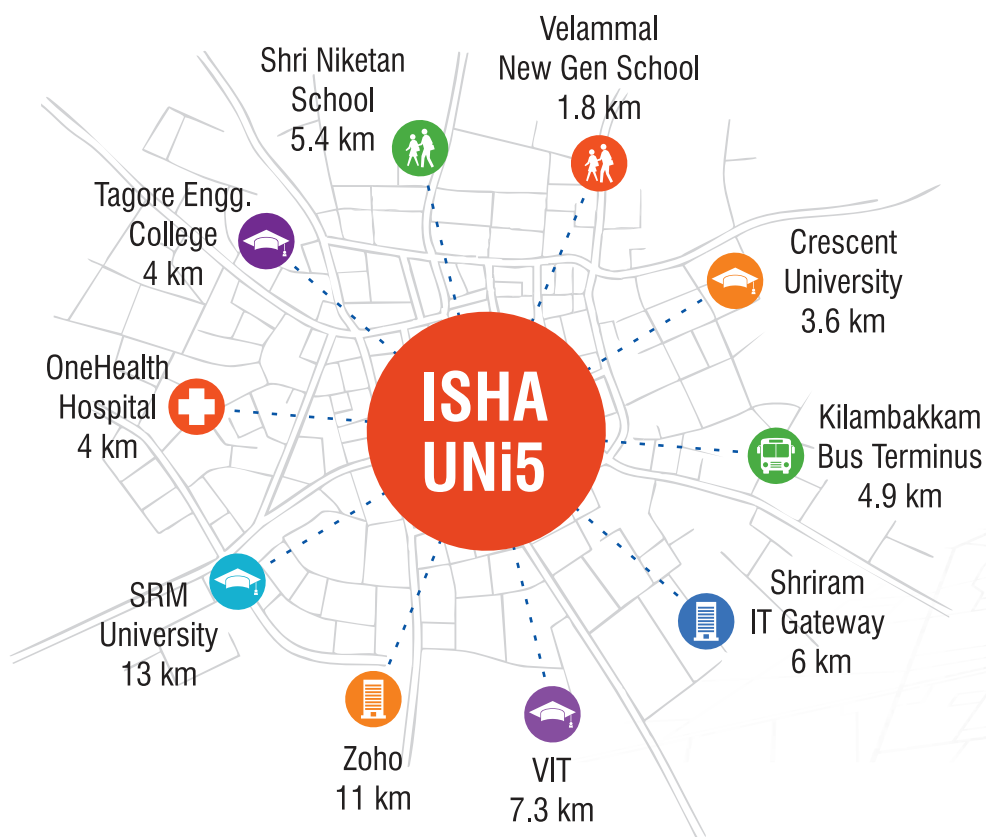
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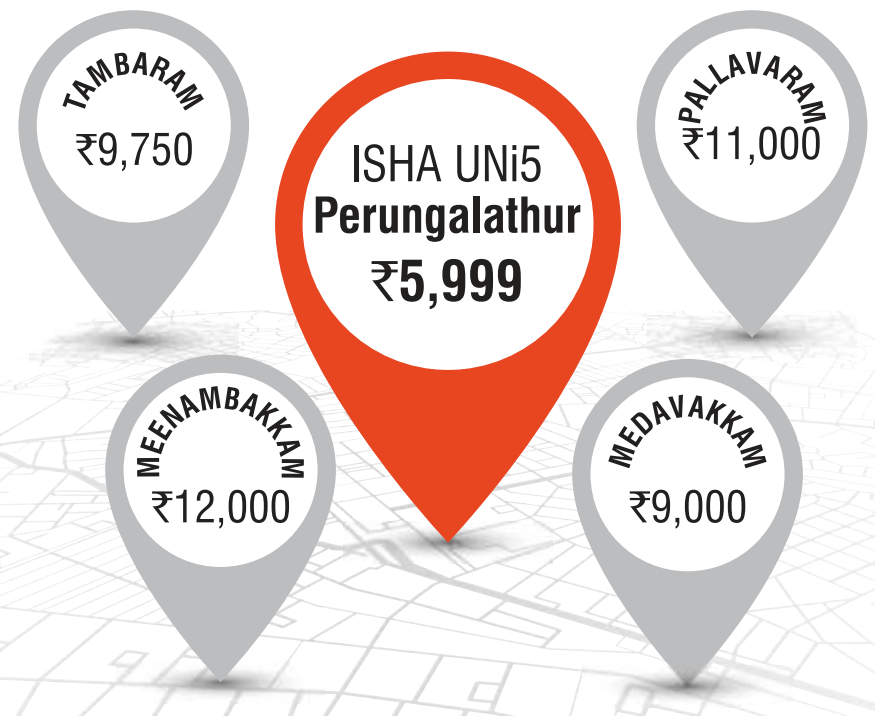


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MALFUNCTION SUSPECTED
Probe ordered into UAV crash in Gujarat

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RENEWED HOSTILITIES
U.S., Iran trade strikes amid funeral of Khamenei

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UNLAWFUL MINING
CISF seizes over 400 tonnes of illegal coal

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PARLEY
Should India restart dialogue with Pakistan?

Breaking down the neighbours' standpoints

OPINION » PAGE 9



HISTORIC OCCASION
India meets England in a Test at Lord's

SPORT » PAGE 18



NEARBY

CM to give job orders to kin of stampede victims

CHENNAI
Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will on Friday hand over appointment orders for government jobs to the family members of 32 victims of the stampede that took place during a TVK rally in Karur last year. » PAGE 6



TVK govt. begins consultations for industrial policy

CHENNAI
The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam-led government has begun consultations to formulate its first industrial policy for Tamil Nadu, which is expected to be unveiled in January 2027. » PAGE 6



'No delay in textbooks supply to govt. schools'

CHENNAI
The Tamil Nadu School Education Department on Thursday said there had not been any delay in the printing or supply of textbooks to government schools across the State for the current academic year. » PAGE 6

FRIDAY REVIEW » 8 PAGES

India, Australia move to deepen cooperation in the Indo-Pacific

Amid geostrategic uncertainties, Prime Minister Modi, his Australian counterpart, Albanese, adopt declaration to expand maritime security ties and defence collaboration; the countries also seal pacts on civil nuclear energy and critical minerals

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India and Australia on Thursday adopted a Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation, committing to significantly deepen military engagement, strengthen defence industrial collaboration, and expand maritime security cooperation amid growing geostrategic uncertainty in the Indo-Pacific region. The two countries also sealed pacts on civil nuclear energy and critical minerals sectors.

The declaration, adopted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Australian counterpart, Anthony Albanese, outlines an ambitious road map to elevate defence ties through closer strategic consultations, enhanced

interoperability between the armed forces, expanded military exercises, and greater collaboration in defence science, technology, and industrial supply chains. A statement released by the office of the Australian Prime Minister mentioned that, under the declaration, the two sides agreed to hold regular consultations on defence-related developments in the Indo-Pacific affecting their shared interests, increase the complexity of bilateral and multilateral military exercises, accelerate efforts to improve interoperability and information sharing between their armed forces, and expand aircraft deployments from each other's territories.

The agreement also envisages deeper personnel exchanges through educa-



Tactical ties: PM Narendra Modi being greeted by his Australian counterpart, Anthony Albanese, in Melbourne on Thursday. AP

tion, training, and liaison appointments, while exploring opportunities to cooperate in recruiting skilled personnel for their respective defence workforces.

Mr. Modi emphasised the importance of a free and stable Indo-Pacific and highlighted the growing engagement between the

two countries in the defence domain. "The Indo-Pacific is not just the confluence of two oceans. It also symbolises the shared aspirations of like-minded democracies like India and Australia," he said.

The agreement on civil nuclear energy to facilitate the commercial supply of uranium from Australia to

India to fuel nuclear power projects came nearly 12 years after the two countries inked a historic civil nuclear cooperation pact.

"Today, we have signed an important agreement in the field of nuclear energy. This will open the way for uranium supplies from Australia and give new impetus to our clean energy objectives," Mr. Modi said.

He also announced the launch of the Australia-India Partnership on Cyber, Critical Technologies, and Supply Chains and said both sides will also work together on a critical minerals corridor.

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ANTIQUITIES REPATRIATION
» PAGE 4
CALL FOR DIALOGUE
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Four Indian nationals pushed into Bangladesh return home

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Four people from Birbhum in West Bengal, detained by the Delhi Police last year and pushed into Bangladesh, were brought back to India on Wednesday after a year-long legal battle. The group of returnees included Sweetie Bibi, her two minor sons, and Danish Sheikh, who were picked up by the police along with two others from the national capital in May last year over suspicion of being infiltrators and later pushed across the border into Bangladesh.

In December 2025, Sunali Khatun, wife of Mr. Sheikh, and her minor son had returned to India after the Supreme Court inter-



Sweetie Bibi, one of the four returnees, in Malda, West Bengal, on Wednesday. PTI

vened. Ms. Khatun was pregnant at that time and her father had argued that if his daughter gave birth in Bangladesh, the child would have no claim to an Indian citizenship. After her return, Ms. Khatun gave birth to a child in a State-run hospital in West Bengal in January.

Trinamool Congress leader Samirul Islam on Thursday applauded the Indian judiciary for its help in bringing back the remaining four, who returned through the border in Malda district. He said that while there is no problem with the deportation of illegal migrants, Indian nationals should not be subjected to injustice and harassment. "They stayed there [Bangladesh] for over a year. Even Bangladesh had written letters that Indians who were pushed back illegally must be taken back, but it took such a long time," Mr. Islam, Trinamool MP and former chairperson of the West Bengal Migrant Welfare Board, told *The Hindu* on Thursday.

Time's up



The iconic clock tower of Kozhikode railway station that collapsed amid heavy rain on Thursday. It was set for a controlled demolition later in the day after developing cracks recently. K. RAGESH (REPORT: PAGE 7)

SC considers reference of provision to furnish reason during arrests

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday indicated that the Meghalaya government's appeal against the grant of bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi, accused of murdering her newlywed husband Raja Raghuvanshi, may have to be referred to a larger Bench in view of conflicting decisions of coordinate Benches on whether the grounds of arrest must necessarily be furnished to an accused in writing.

The State was appealing against a June 29 order of the Meghalaya High Court, which had upheld a trial court's decision granting bail to Ms. Raghuvanshi saying that the police had failed to effectively communicate the grounds of her arrest. "Basically, the issue is whether written grounds of arrest are mandatory or not... We will decide whether the matter requires to be referred to a larger Bench. There is a conflict arising from different coordinate Bench judgments," the Bench comprising Justices Manoj Misra and Shree Chandrasekhar said.

The Bench directed Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the State, to file written submissions along with photocopies of the documents furnished to the accused so that it could examine the exact nature of the information communicated at the time of arrest. The matter has been posted for further hearing on July 14.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Vikram Solar to set up battery storage plant in Tirunelveli

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government on Thursday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Vikram Solar Limited to establish a Battery Energy Storage Systems manufacturing facility at the SIP-COT Industrial Park at Gangaikondan in Tirunelveli.

The plant, which will come up at an investment of ₹15,037 crore, is expected to create jobs for 2,670 people. The Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department and the company signed the MoU in the presence of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Secretariat. According to an official



Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the signing of the MoU between the Tamil Nadu government and Vikram Solar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

release, Vikram Solar operates solar photovoltaic (PV) module manufacturing units at Oragadam and Valam. It has also established an integrated manufacturing facility for solar PV cells and modules at Gangaikondan.

Minister for Industries S. Keerthana; Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar; Addi-

tional Chief Secretary, Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce, S. Vijayakumar; Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Guidence Tamil Nadu Deepak Jacob; Vikram Solar chairman and managing director Gyanesh Chaudhary; and senior officials were among those present.

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The southwest monsoon covered the entire country on Thursday, a day later than its normal date, after advancing into the remaining parts of the north Arabian Sea, Rajasthan, Haryana, and Punjab, India Meteorological Department (IMD) officials said.

The nationwide coverage came 35 days after the monsoon reached Kerala on June 5. While the advance was slower than in recent years, the July 9 date is not unusual historically.

Since 1971, the monsoon has covered the country on dates ranging from June 16 in 2013 to August 15 in



Water traffic: Children have fun in a waterlogged road after a heavy spell of rain in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

2002, according to IMD data.

The monsoon's progress has accelerated over the past week, accompanied by widespread heavy rain across several parts of the country. Delhi and the Na-

tional Capital Region received significant rainfall overnight and on Thursday, causing waterlogging and traffic disruptions in several areas.

The recent wet spell, however, does not necessari-

ly indicate how rainfall will evolve through the rest of the month.

The IMD has forecast below-normal rainfall for the country as a whole in July, defined as less than 94% of the long-period average, even as some parts of northwest and northeast India, east-central India, and the eastern peninsula may receive normal to above-normal rainfall. July receives the highest rainfall among the monsoon months and is critical for agriculture.

India's current monsoon rainfall deficit stands at 15%, a sharp improvement from 38% on June 30.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

INBRIEF



Round-the-clock cleaning taken up at city’s beaches

A total of 152 sanitation workers and assistants, with nine beach-cleaning machines and other vehicles, were engaged in round-the-clock cleaning operations at the city’s beaches, including Marina Beach. According to a press release, the work is being carried out in three shifts to maintain cleanliness. A third Blue Flag project on the Marina Beach is nearing completion, while work on the fourth and fifth projects is under way. The Corporation has also planted 650 native saplings in the Blue Flag beach area. The civic body appealed to visitors to dispose waste only in designated bins to help keep the beaches clean and hygienic.

Police remove over 2,200 abandoned vehicles in city

The Greater Chennai Police have removed 2,243 abandoned vehicles that had been parked along roadsides, causing traffic obstruction in Adyar, Kilpauk, St. Thomas Mount, Flower Bazaar, T. Nagar, and Anna Nagar police station limits. Details of the vehicles have been uploaded on the Greater Chennai Corporations’s website. Owners have been asked to claim their vehicles from the respective police stations within 15 days. Unclaimed vehicles will be disposed of through e-auction.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper, thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (July 10, Friday), the following articles are available:

- Why is the Centre revising the NFSA? newsth.live/foodsecuritylaw
- Why more Indian couples are being diagnosed with secondary infertility newsth.live/infertilitysecond

You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access these articles. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Residential market in city remained stable during first half of 2026: report

Sales grew by 3% YoY to 9,198 units, while launches dipped by 0.3% YoY to 9,588 units; Perambur, Perumbakkam and Mogappair saw high demand for homes, but affordable housing saw sharp fall

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai’s residential market remained stable during the first half of 2026, despite Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, with housing sales growing by 3% year on year (YoY) to 9,198 units, while launches dipped moderately by 0.3% YoY at 9,588 units. Average residential prices appreciated by 5% YoY to ₹7,555 per sq.ft, according to Knight Frank India’s latest report, India Real Estate: Residential and Office H1 2026 (January-June 2026).

Homes priced between ₹50 lakh and ₹1 crore remained the largest contributor to residential sales, accounting for 47% of total transactions. The ₹1 crore to ₹2 crore segment increased its share to 27%, while homes priced between ₹2 crore and ₹5 crore accounted for 12% of overall sales, reflecting rising buyer preference for larger homes. The affordable housing segment priced below ₹50 lakh witnessed its share decline sharply from 22% in H1 2025 to 12% in H1 2026, highlighting the impact of affordability pressures, rising input costs and constrained supply.

According to the report, average residential prices in Chennai increased 5% YoY to ₹7,555 per sq.ft. Pe-



Growth hotspot: Office market continued to demonstrate resilience in the first half of 2026, recording 3.6 million sq.ft. of leasing activity. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

rambur registered the strongest appreciation with a 35% YoY increase, bringing the average prices in the range of ₹10,563-₹11,158 sq.ft per month, driven by infrastructure upgrades and enhanced metro connectivity. Perumbakkam recorded a 20% YoY rise owing to its proximity to the OMR employment corridor and upcoming Metro Phase II connectivity, while Mogappair witnessed 13% YoY appreciation, supported by strong end-user demand and established social infrastructure.

Joseph Thilak, National Director - Occupier Strategy and Solutions (Hyderabad & Chennai), Knight Frank India, said, “We are

also witnessing a clear evolution in buyer preferences, with demand increasingly shifting towards mid and premium housing segments as consumers seek larger homes, better amenities and improved lifestyles. Looking ahead, continued investments in manufacturing, Global Capability Centres (GCC), Metro Rail connectivity and major infrastructure projects such as Chennai Metro Phase II are expected to further strengthen housing demand and reinforce Chennai’s position as one of India’s most stable residential markets.”

Chennai’s office market continued to demonstrate resilience in the first half of 2026, recording 3.6 million sq.ft. of leasing activity.

While transaction volumes fell by 28% YoY compared with the exceptionally strong H1 2025, leasing activity remained among the highest ever recorded for a first-half period.

“Although leasing activity moderated compared with the record levels witnessed last year, transaction volumes remain among the strongest ever recorded, highlighting the city’s enduring attractiveness to both domestic and global occupiers. We are seeing demand broaden beyond Global Capability Centres (GCCs) to include flexible office spaces and India-facing businesses, creating a more diversified and balanced occupier ecosystem,” Mr. Thilak said.

T.N. continues to record high GER in primary education

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu continues to record a high gross enrollment ratio (GER) at the primary level with 92%, according to the Unified District Information System for Education (UDISE) 2025-2026 which was released by the Ministry of

Education recently. While the GER for upper primary saw a small decrease from 98% to 95% compared to last year, the State saw a marginal increase in secondary enrollment at 97%. However, the GER for higher secondary section, while recording an improvement, still stood at 85%, a far cry from the en-

rollment of the secondary level. The report also said that Tamil Nadu has maintained a zero-dropout rate at the primary and upper primary level, but saw a 6.2% dropout at the secondary level. The retention rate, which also follows the same pattern, was 94% at primary level and 96% till

Class 8, but fell to 75.9% at higher secondary schooling. In Tamil Nadu, private schools’ enrollment is higher compared to the government schools with a difference of over 18 lakh students. According to the report, private schools have over 62 lakh students enrolled, while govern-

ment schools see only over 43 lakh students. The trend has been observed nationally too. The government-aided schools in the State saw an enrollment of over 18 lakh students. The School Education Department noted in a press release that the State has an overall Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR) of 22, while

the national average is 24. It also noted that during the academic year 2025-26, 83,600 students secured admission to polytechnic institutions and 60,355 students joined Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs), taking the total number entering organised technical and vocational education to 1,43,955.

Police nab gangster at gunpoint from hotel

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A history-sheeter, along with five other associates, was arrested at gunpoint from a star hotel near Guindy on Thursday, police said. The accused, Dhana-sekar, a resident of Ennore, had been absconding in connection with several cases, including alleged extortion of industrialists. Acting on the instructions of the Avadi city Police Commissioner, a special team of police personnel from the Ennore police station surrounded the hotel and apprehended him after a swift operation, sources said. The police seized a firearm, a luxury car, and a mobile phone from his possession. Further investigation is under way. Dhanasekar was also wanted in connection with an extortion case of ₹1 crore from a businessman in Kattur.

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INBRIEF



DIG Varun Kumar shifted to Special Task Force

IPS officer V. Varun Kumar has been posted as Deputy Inspector General of Police, Special Task Force, Erode, after being transferred from the post of DIG, Crime Branch CID, Chennai. V. Vikraman who was on 'compulsory wait' has been posted as CB-CID DIG. B. Ragupathi, Superintendent of Police, who was also on 'compulsory wait' has been posted as Deputy Commissioner of Police, Pallikaranai, Tambaram City Police.

US Consul General meets Chennai Mayor Priya

Mariana L. Neisuler, Consul General of the United States met Chennai Mayor R. Priya on Thursday at the Greater Chennai Corporation headquarters. A press release from the Corporation termed the visit as a courtesy call.

Australia to return three antiquities stolen from temples in Tamil Nadu

The stolen artefacts include a Chola-era bronze trident, a granite Nandi idol, and a Karthikeya sculpture; all these items date back to the 11th and 12th Centuries and were originally sourced from temples in the State. The repatriation comes in the wake of Prime Minister Modi's visit to Australia

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Australia will repatriate three ancient artefacts stolen from temples in Tamil Nadu, including a Chola-era bronze trident, a granite Nandi idol and a Karthikeya sculpture, in a move announced during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the country.

The Union Ministry of Culture said in a press statement, "In a profound testament to the civilisational resonance anchoring modern diplomacy, Australia is set to repatriate three culturally significant ancient antiquities to India. These artefacts include a ceremonial bronze trident of Goddess Bhadrakali, a majestic granite idol of Nandi, and a basalt



Nandi idol



Karthikeya (Shanmukha)



Bhadrakali Trident

sculpture depicting the six-headed Karthikeya." All these items date back to the 11th and 12th Centuries and were originally sourced from temples in Tamil Nadu. The official announcement of the repatriation coincides with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Australia, further emphasising the strong cultural alignment between the two nations, the Ministry said.

The three antiquities, currently housed in the National Gallery of Australia, are being repatriated under the Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty (MLAT) after investigations by the Tamil Nadu Idol Wing CID established that they had been removed from temples in Tamil Nadu and trafficked overseas.

Commenting on the repatriation of the idols, S. Vijaya Kumar, cultural en-

thusiast and co-founder of India Pride, said the return of these three artefacts marks the conclusion of a process that should have happened many years ago.

More than a decade has passed since the National Gallery of Australia's independent provenance review by former High Court Justice Susan Crennan AC identified significant shortcomings in the provenance of these objects. The re-

view concluded that the ownership histories of two idols did not establish lawful export from India.

The Bhadrakali Trident was acquired from Temple Gallery, New York, with a provenance tracing ownership only to Dr. P.S. Rao, Chennai, before entering the gallery in 1993. Justice Crennan concluded that this ownership history did not establish that the object had been legally exported. It has now been identified as originating from Sri Kasi Viswanatha Swamy Temple, Kolluman-gudi, Tiruvarur district.

The Stone Nandi was purchased from Carlton Rochell Asian Art based on an elaborate provenance claiming that Mexican diplomat Mario Calderon had assembled the sculpture in Goa before it passed

through inheritance to Pedro Silva Villaseñor in Mexico. The Crennan Review found that this ownership chain was not convincingly corroborated, and subsequent investigation identified the sculpture as originating from the temple in Tamil Nadu.

The Karthikeya (Shanmukha) followed a provenance similar to the Bhadrakali Trident, again relying upon ownership through Dr. P.S. Rao and Temple Gallery. Justice Crennan's review concluded that there was insufficient evidence to establish a lawful export from India. It has now been identified as originating from Naganathaswamy Temple, Manambadi, Thanjavur, built during the reign of Rajendra Chola I, said Mr. Vijaya-kumar.

CIC directs Southern Railway to disclose details of 83,000 trees planted in Madurai Division

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the Madurai Division of Southern Railway to disclose details of trees planted over a six-year period, including the species, locations, and expenditure incurred.

The direction follows a petition filed under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, by Arun Pandi, who sought the details of about 83,000 trees planted across the Madurai Division between April 2019 and July 2024. He requested information on the exact locations where the saplings were planted, the species of trees, the expenditure incurred, and the source of procurement along with copies of purchase bills.

In response, the Central Public Information Officer

(CPIO) said the information sought was not available at the divisional office. While some details were available at the field offices, compiling them would not only be time-consuming, but would also disproportionately divert the resources of the public authority, he said.

Dissatisfied with the response of the CPIO and the order of the First Appellate Authority, Mr. Pandi approached the CIC. During the hearing, the CPIO reiterated that the information sought was voluminous and not maintained in a compiled form. After hearing both sides, Information Commissioner Swagat Das observed that the CPIO's reply was vague and generic. The officer had merely stated that the information was unavailable at the divisional office and that compiling records from various field units would dispro-

portionately divert the authority's resources, without providing any specific justification regarding the availability or non-availability of each item of information sought by the appellant.

The Commissioner said the information sought ought to exist in one form or another at the concerned offices maintaining plantation and expenditure records. "A blanket denial stating that the information is not available with the office, without examining the records held by the concerned field units, is not in consonance with the provisions of the RTI Act," he said. The Commission directed the CPIO to revisit the RTI application, conduct a diligent search of records available with the concerned offices and field units, and furnish all available information to the petitioner.

Wet spell



Rain lashed parts of the city on Thursday, providing residents a much-needed respite from heat. R. RAGU

TNCC chief criticises 'sudden alteration' of FMGE exam pattern

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president Manickam Tagore has alleged that injustice has been meted out to students who took the Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE).

The FMGE examination is being conducted by the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS). Pointing out the drastic drop in the pass percentage in the exam results, Mr. Tagore said the sudden alteration in the ex-

am pattern was the primary reason behind it.

"Without any prior notice, the NBEMS introduced massive changes to the examination pattern – such as lengthy questions, video-based questions, and clinical/practical-oriented questions. Due to this, the pass percentage has shockingly plummeted to 12.78. Out of the 36,280 candidates who appeared for the exam, only 4,635 have passed. Candidates should have been given adequate time to prepare for such major changes," he said in a statement.

Man held in ₹5.8-crore investment fraud case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Cyber Crime Wing of the Greater Chennai Police arrested a 34-year-old man in connection with an alleged ₹5.8-crore investment fraud in which a businessman was lured into investing in fake forex and stock trading platforms with the promise of high returns.

The police said the case was registered based on a complaint by R.A. Khaleel Ahmed, 43, of Anna Nagar

West Extension, who alleged that he was introduced to forex trading by Mahesh of Madurai and C. Saravanakumar of Madathukulam.

Investigation revealed that the accused had been operating the complainant's demat and trading accounts for several years and gradually diverted his investments to multiple fictitious trading platforms. The Cyber Crime Wing arrested C. Saravanakumar and remanded him to judicial custody.

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OIPR-1001/1533/126-27/0008

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No.EE/KEN/TEND/06/2026-27 Date: 09.07.2026
INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (IFT) (Tender Notification) Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal)
The Executive Engineer, Kengeri Division, ZONE-1 invites tenders on behalf of the Commissioner, BWCC, Bengaluru from eligible Tenderers for the construction of works detailed in the table below. The Tenderers may submit tenders for works given in the table through e-procurement portal of the Government of Karnataka (viz <http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>). The Tenderers are advised to note the minimum qualification criteria specified in Clause 3 of the Instructions to Tenderers to qualify for award of the contract. 2.Tender documents may be downloaded from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal of the Government of Karnataka Date: 10.07.2026 . 3.Tenders must be submitted online through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal on or before 16.00 hours on Date:22.07.2026 4. Other details can be seen in the tender document.
Sl. No. Name of the Work/Approximate value of work (Rs in Lakhs)/ EMD amount in Rs.
TWO COVER SYSTEM, Call-1, Period of Completion : 6 Months
1 Improvements of Roads and Drains Shivanagara, Akkipikki colony and Surrounding areas in ward No.18, Kengal Hanumanthaiah West. Approximate Value of work : Rs. 120.09 Lakhs, EMD : Rs. 2,00,000/-
2 Improvements of Roads and Drains Gandhinagara and Surrounding areas in ward No.18, Kengal Hanumanthaiah West. Approximate Value of work : Rs. 119.02 Lakhs , EMD : Rs. 2,00,000/-
3 Comprehensive Development of Roads and Drains and other Improvement works at Pattanagere and Surrounding Area in Ward No-21, Kengeri. Approximate Value of work : Rs. 120.09 Lakhs , EMD : Rs. 2,00,000/-
1) Tender Documents may be downloaded through e-portal from : 10.07.2026 4.00PM. 2) Pre bid meeting : 15.07.2026 @ 3.00PM O/o Chief Engineer, Ideal Homes, Rajarajeswari Nagar Zone, Blore-98. 3) Last date & Time for receipt of Tenders : 22.07.2026 Upto 4.00PM. 4) Opening of Bids : 23.07.2026 Upto 4.30PM. 5) Validity of Tenders : 6 Months after the dead line date for Tender submission. 6) Bid Validity : 90days
Sd/- Executive Engineer Kengeri division, BWCC, Zone-1

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE
DEATH
OBITUARY
Mrs. UPPU SHANTHA KUMARI
89 YEARS
W/o Thiru. UPPU SHOBHAN BABU (ACTOR)
Expired on 09.07.2026 at 5:30 pm
Funeral on 10.07.2026 4 pm at
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Son:- UPPU KARUNASESH & FAMILY
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Panel to be formed to examine liquor retail models in other States, says Minister

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

From shutting down liquor outlets near schools and places of worship to cracking down on overcharging at Tasmac counters and announcing a 25% salary increase for workers, the Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK) government has initiated a series of reforms in the State-run liquor retail system.

Its latest proposal is to constitute a high-level committee to study the functioning of excise and liquor retail departments in other States so as to introduce further reforms in Tamil Nadu.

Minister for Prohibition and Excise K. Vignesh told *The Hindu* that the committee would be formed soon.

“The committee will study the functioning of excise departments in Kerala, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and Odisha, among other States, including liquor procurement, retail operations, and employee service con-



K. Vignesh

ditions,” he said.

“Based on its findings, the government would take steps to address employees’ demands,” he said.

The order to constitute the committee would be issued under the directions of Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, he added.

Tasmac, a major revenue generator for the Tamil Nadu government, operates 4,048 retail liquor outlets across the State. It generates around ₹150 crore from liquor sales every day through its retail network.

Madras High Court stays Look Out Circular against former Minister E.V. Velu

Justice G.K. Ilanthiraiyan grants interim stay on the condition that Velu must appear for an inquiry before the DVAC investigating officer on July 15, after returning from Singapore on July 12

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Thursday stayed the operation of a Look Out Circular (LoC) issued against former DMK Minister E.V. Velu in connection with a recent case registered against him by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC).

Justice G.K. Ilanthiraiyan granted the interim stay on the condition that Mr. Velu appear before the investigating officer on July 15. The judge took note that the petitioner was currently in Singapore for medical treatment, and was scheduled to return to India only on July 12.

The judge also restrained the DVAC from taking coercive action against the petitioner till July 28, by when the investigating agency was expected to file its counter-affidavit in res-



E.V. Velu

ponse to the former Minister’s plea to quash the First Information Report (FIR) registered on June 26.

The court passed the interim orders after hearing senior counsel Siddharth Luthra and P. Wilson, appearing for Mr. Velu, and Government Counsel (criminal side) R. John Sathyan, appearing for the DVAC.

The petitioner’s counsel contended that the FIR had been registered without obtaining the Governor’s consent. Further, highlighting that the FIR had been

registered in 2026 for an alleged offence of private contractors of the State Highways Department having been paid money even before the laying of roads in many districts in 2022, they said there was also an inordinate delay of four years in registering the case.

Mr. Wilson said the former Minister had cooperated with the DVAC when it conducted searches at his residence immediately after the registration of the FIR, and thereafter left for Singapore for medical treatment. However, the DVAC had served summons on him at his residence on June 30.

The first summons required him to appear before the investigating officer for an inquiry on July 3. The petitioner replied that he would return to India only on July 12. Yet, the DVAC issued another summons on July 4, and this

time, he was asked to appear on July 9. “The second summons specifically stated that failure to attend the inquiry today (July 9) would render the petitioner liable for arrest. Therefore, there is an imminent necessity to protect the life and liberty of the petitioner. He is over 70 years old and a heart patient,” the senior counsel told the court.

Governor’s sanction

On the other hand, Mr. Sathyan contended that there was no necessity for the Governor to accord sanction for registering the FIR in the present case, and that it was sufficient if the Chief Minister accorded sanction.

He also said the complainant, Jayaram Venkatesan of Arappor Iyakkam, had not been included as a respondent in the present petitions filed for quashing the FIR and rescinding the LoC.



Two former Ministers skip review meetings chaired by Palaniswami

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

Two former Ministers of the AIADMK did not turn up for the party’s district-wise consultations chaired by general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Thursday.

P. Balakrishna Reddy of Hosur and K.P. Anbalagan of Palacode were absent at the review sessions held for Krishnagiri and Dharmapuri, respectively.

“I joined the party in 2006. I worked for 20 years. Now, they are making all sorts of changes. Let them do it. I didn’t attend because I was out of town. That’s all,” Mr. Reddy told *The Hindu*.

“I just stayed back in my hometown. There is no other reason,” Mr. Anbalagan said.

In Krishnagiri, which has six seats, the Dravidian

major won two seats – Bargur and Hosur.

Out of five seats in Dharmapuri, it bagged three – Palacode, Pappireddipatti and Harur. Its ally, the PMK, cornered Dharmapuri. In total, the AIADMK-led combine got four seats.

Mr. Reddy and Mr. Anbalagan were among the 25 dissidents who had supported the TVK at the time of the trust motion in the Assembly in May. For their defiance of the party’s line of approach, the two were stripped of the post of district secretary for Krishnagiri (west) and Dharmapuri units. Though Mr. Palaniswami sought to accommodate them and many such dissidents by offering other positions, the two former Ministers, along with seven others, wrote to him that they would prefer to remain “ordinary workers”.

T.N. govt. reconstitutes SC/ST Vigilance and Monitoring Committee

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has reconstituted the State Vigilance and Monitoring Committee for Sched-

uled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

The Chief Minister will be the Chairman of the committee, while 59 individuals, including all elected representatives to Parlia-

ment and the Assembly from the State, who belong to the SCs and STs, have been inducted as members.

The Ministers in charge of Home, Finance and Social Justice Departments,

the Chief Secretary, the Home Secretary, the DGP, and two representatives from the National Commission for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes will automatically become

members of the committee. Since Mr. Vijay holds the Home portfolio, Finance Minister N. Marie Wilson and Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu have been included as members. Seven

other Ministers, a Rajya Sabha member, and seven Lok Sabha MPs, all belonging to the SCs; and 37 MLAs belonging to the SCs/STs have also been included as members.

TVK government changes the name of free bus travel scheme for women



In Chennai alone, women have been availing themselves of free travel on 1,500 ordinary-fare buses, according to a senior official of the Metropolitan Transport Corporation. FILE PHOTO

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The TVK government has changed the name of the free bus travel scheme for women from ‘Mahalir Vidiyal Payanam’, as it was named by the DMK government, to ‘Magalir Payanam’.

Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) buses sported ‘Magalir Payanam’ boards on Thursday. The word, ‘Vidiyal’, has been removed from the ordinary-fare buses meant for the scheme. A senior official of the Transport Department said the MTC branch managers had been instructed to implement the name change across all the ordinary-fare buses.

After assuming office on May 7, 2021, the M.K. Stalin-led DMK government implemented ‘Vidiyal Payanam’ for women to travel free on white-board buses. The scheme covered more than 7,300 ordinary-fare buses out of the 9,000 city buses oper-

ated by the State Transport Corporations. In Chennai alone, women have been availing themselves of free travel on 1,500 ordinary-fare buses, a senior official of the MTC said.

Meanwhile, DMK leader and former Minister Thangam Thennarasu wrote on X, “You can change the name; but history cannot be changed.”

In his post, he said that renaming the ‘Mahalir Vidiyal Payanam’ scheme, which had brought about a significant change in the lives of women, was not an administrative measure meant for public welfare; it was merely an attempt to erase political identities. The success of a scheme would not be determined by its name; it would be determined by the progress it had brought about in the lives of the people. The time and energy spent on name changes should be invested in new schemes to improve people’s livelihood and strengthen services, he added.

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INBRIEF



Is CM ready to warn Congress over Cauvery issue, asks EPS

AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami sought to know whether Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay was prepared to announce the removal of Congress Ministers from the State Cabinet if Karnataka failed to release Tamil Nadu's share of Cauvery water. He condemned Karnataka's Water Resources Minister Ramalinga Reddy's statement that the Cauvery Water Management Authority had not ordered the release of water, and that Tamil Nadu had not requested its rightful share.

Minister's claims on airport site 'false propaganda': BJP

BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran said on Thursday that Minister C.T.R. Nirmalkumar's contention that it would not be possible to lay a runway at the Parandur site for the new airport was part of a "false propaganda" and amounted to betrayal of Tamil Nadu. He said the TVK-led government had taken steps to stall the State's economic development and employment generation by creating hurdles to the project. Stating that any delay in the project would cost Tamil Nadu investment opportunities, he urged the State government to cooperate with the Centre to take the project forward.

TVK-led government begins consultations with experts for its first industrial policy

It holds the first meeting with representatives from the electronics and semiconductor ecosystem to gather industry perspectives on growth opportunities, key challenges, and policy interventions

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

The Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government in Tamil Nadu has begun the groundwork for its first industrial policy, which is slated to be rolled out in January 2027.

As part of the process, the government has started consultations with sector experts, with the first meeting bringing together representatives from the electronics and semiconductor ecosystem to gather industry perspectives on the growth opportunities, key challenges, and policy interventions required to strengthen the sector.

The meeting was chaired by S. Vijayakumar, Additional Chief Secretary, Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department. Deepak Jacob, Managing Director and CEO of Guidance, the nodal agency instrumental



Participants shared their feedback and highlighted measures to support emerging and future-ready sectors. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

in drawing investments to Tamil Nadu, was also present. Guidance Tamil Nadu, in collaboration with Electronic Industries Association of India and the India Cellular & Electronics Association, conducted the Tamil Nadu Industrial Policy Stakeholders' Connect.

Participants shared feedback through a structured survey, highlighting priority areas for policy intervention, steps to sup-

port emerging and future-ready sectors, and recommendations to boost local demand and build a stronger industrial ecosystem.

"Tamil Nadu leads in electronics export with 41% (national share) and has launched its own Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Mission 2030. As a critical sector, the first level of industry stakeholder discussion was held this week. Further stakeholder discussion

with other sectors will happen in the coming weeks," Mr. Jacob said.

Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, on June 18, had told the Assembly, "With an aim of promoting the State's economic stability and industrial growth, while maintaining continuity with the previous industrial policies, this government will notify a new industrial policy that considers the present and future requirements and offers special incentive schemes for domestic and global companies to make fresh investments in Tamil Nadu."

Review meeting

Meanwhile, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay met officials of the Industries Department on Thursday for a review meeting. "We had discussions about the industrial policy and the vision document, among other issues," a senior official said.

No delay in supply of textbooks to govt. schools, says School Education Dept.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu School Education Department said on Thursday that there had been no delay in the printing or initial supply of textbooks to government schools for the current academic year.

"Any temporary shortage reported in certain schools was only on account of fresh admissions after the academic year commenced and not due to any deficiency in the department's planning or printing process," the department said in a press release.

The clarification came after *The Hindu* reported that many government schools in the State were yet to receive the textbooks, particularly those for Classes IV and V. Many teachers, too, said they were yet to receive the handbooks meant for planning lessons in line with the new curriculum for Classes I-III, which was implemented this academic year.

The release said the text-

The department cites new admissions for any temporary shortage reported in certain schools

books were printed and supplied on the basis of the student strength furnished by the schools well before the academic year started, and an additional requirement of about 80,000 textbooks was identified owing to new admissions. "The department printed and distributed this additional quantity. The supply has been completed, and the distribution process to the schools is being finalised," it added.

This additional supply also includes the requisite workbooks, ensuring that newly admitted students received the complete set of learning materials, the release said. "The department has taken prompt action to meet the revised demand, and all eligible students will have access to the required textbooks and workbooks," it added.

Leopard trapped in snare rescued and released into Mudumalai Tiger Reserve

The Hindu Bureau
UDHAGAMANDALAM

A leopard trapped in a snare laid on agricultural land at Pattavayal in the Gudalur forest division in the Nilgiris was rescued by the Forest Department and released into the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve (MTR) early on Thursday.

The Forest Department said they received information that a leopard was trapped in the fence on the land of N.C. Krishnan, a resident of Velleri in Pattavayal, around 8 p.m. on Wednesday. Once they reached the spot, they learnt that the animal had been caught in a snare placed around the farm.

Veterinary assistant surgeon from MTR K. Rajesh Kumar was involved in the rescue operation.

The Forest Department said the animal was res-



Saving the big cat: The leopard being taken for release into the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

cued and treated for its injuries, and brought in a specially-designed cage to the tiger reserve.

Following the release, the Forest Department began an investigation to identify the individual responsible for laying the snare and arrested K. Balan, a 40-year-old daily wage worker.

He confessed to having laid the trap for small wild game, officials said.

In a separate incident, a tiger was found dead in the Sigur forest range in the buffer zone of the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve on Wednesday.

Officials said the carcass was discovered by field staff during a routine patrol. A post-mortem was conducted on the carcass, following which it was destroyed. Officials said preliminary investigations pointed to natural death.

CM to hand over govt. job appointment orders to kin of 32 stampede victims

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will visit Karur on Friday and meet the family members of the victims who died in the stampede that occurred during a TVK rally on September 27 last year.

He will hand over appointment orders on compassionate grounds to the family members of 32 victims. They will be appointed to various government departments based on their educational qualifications, official sources said.

Mr. Vijay will also lay the foundation stone for Evervan Kothari Footwear Private Limited, which will come up at Manavasi near Krishnarayapuram with an investment of ₹1,700 crore.

The non-leather footwear manufacturing unit is expected to generate employment for about 13,500 people.

Mr. Vijay will travel to Tiruchi by flight on Friday



The stampede occurred during a rally addressed by TVK president C. Joseph Vijay in Karur on September 27 last year. FILE PHOTO

morning and reach Karur by road around 11 a.m. This will be Mr. Vijay's first visit to Karur after assuming office as Chief Minister on May 10. Later, Mr. Vijay will address a public meeting planned by the party on the outskirts of the city.

Left parties' opposition

The CPI and the CPI(M), which are extending outside support to the TVK-led government, have strongly opposed the latter's deci-

sion to offer government jobs to the family members of those killed in the Karur stampede.

CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam said that with an inquiry into the stampede under way and the matter pending before court, the decision to offer government jobs could weaken the legal process. "It will naturally raise the question as to whether the TVK government is using its authority to provide go-

vernment employment to the families of those who died at a TVK rally. The government may facilitate employment in private organisations, but offering government jobs is an entirely different matter," he said in a social media post.

Comprehensive policy

Mr. Shanmugam and CPI State secretary M. Veerapandian said the State government must frame a comprehensive policy for employment of family members of those who died under various circumstances, and must not provide jobs to the kin of the stampede victims until the guidelines are formed.

"Providing government jobs to the families of those who died in a stampede at a political party meeting will set a bad precedent. History will record it as misuse of power, and it will pressure future governments to follow the same practice," senior CPI leader K. Subbarayan said.

'No one must be allowed to enter schools unnecessarily'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

School Education Minister Rajmohan on Thursday directed that no one be allowed to enter school premises unnecessarily.

He said in a statement: "Except for official events organised by the government, no birthday parties or non-government events should be held. No political parties or private organisations are allowed to meet students directly."

This follows a backlash over a video of an inspection carried out by Minister S. Keerthana at a school in Sivakasi, in which she was seen criticising students for their response.

Pointing out that every moment a student spends in the classroom is precious, he said the department would soon issue detailed protocols for conducting events in government schools.

Singer Mano launches platform for fans to showcase talent

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

When a couple, accompanied by their child, told playback singer Mano that his song *Nee Oru Kadhal Sangeetham* from the film *Nayakan* had played a pivotal role in their love story, it reaffirmed his belief that music has the power to create lifelong memories. This memorable interaction happened during an event he organised in the U.S., allowing fans to sing along with him.

"It is not a competition," Mr. Mano said during a freewheeling interaction with *The Hindu*. "The idea is to give ordinary music lovers, who may never otherwise get an opportunity to perform, a platform to sing."

The event "Sing with Mano" will take place in Chennai in October, he said. Participants are encouraged to choose a song of their choice. Mr. Mano will then assess whether it

suits their voice, guide them through rehearsals, and mentor them until they are ready for a performance with him.

Recalling another memorable interaction with fans, he spoke of meeting a group of bus drivers and conductors who told him they regularly listened to his songs while driving. "It is touching to see how music becomes a companion in people's everyday lives," he said.

Born as Nagoor Babu, the singer adopted the screen name "Mano" at the suggestion of music director Ilaiyaraaja, who felt there could be confusion because of another well-known singer Nagoor E.M. Hanifa.

Mr. Mano also recalled his childhood immersion in music. "My father and grandfather were both musicians. We were a family that staged mythological dramas. From a very young age, we visited places of worship of all faiths.



BIJOY GHOSH

By the time I was six or seven, I knew all the characters and the songs we performed," he said.

To illustrate his grounding in classical music, he rendered a Telugu *virutham*. Mr. Mano trained under renowned Carnatic vocalist Nedunuri Krishnamurthy, whose tutelage laid the foundation for his musical journey.

In the film world, Mr. Mano credited his training

in Carnatic music and his two-and-a-half year experience with Tamil composer M.S. Viswanathan for his early success. "Working with him (MSV), I learnt how to write notes. I learnt the different styles of *taalam*. All this was very useful as my musical career progressed," said Mr. Mano, who also had a long-standing relationship with Telugu composer K. Chakravarthy.

Mr. Mano said recording his debut track for Mr. Ilaiyaraaja, *Then Mozhi*, from *Solla Thudikuthu Manasu*, remains one of his most vivid memories. "Raja sir taught me the 'zha' letter, which didn't come to me naturally then," said Mr. Mano, who went on to have a long musical journey with the Isaigani, which includes *Enga Ooru Paatukaaran*, a film in which he sang all the songs. "It was unforgettable. I'm not sure how many singers would have such an experience."

During the conversation, Mr. Mano also addressed the comparisons that music lovers often drew between his voice and that of S.P. Balasubrahmanyam. "In a song in *Jallikattu*, both SPB and I sang together, and I remember Raja sir jokingly asking us who sang which line," recalled the singer, who is also widely celebrated for his versatility across songs such as Sirpy's *Azhagiya*

Laila and A.R. Rahman's *Muqgabula*.

"Singing in commercial films makes you go to a different zone. I grew up as a singer alongside the likes of SPB, Yesudas, and Malaysia Vasudevan - who were giants in the industry - and am grateful to the many composers who gave me opportunities," he said.

Apart from his singing prowess, Mr. Mano also has a solid track record as a dubbing artiste - he has been the voice of several Rajinikanth films in Telugu. Currently, Mano is helming a mentorship programme to give aspiring singers stage opportunities, the Chennai leg of which is scheduled for September this year. "I have seen many ups and downs in life, and have realised that constant practice and passion are the route to success. The younger generation craves instant gratification and success, but I feel that the voice needs daily practice and rigour."

TNPDCL signs MoU with IIT-M to upgrade power infrastructure

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDCL) on Thursday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with IIT Madras to technically strengthen the State's power infrastructure, enhance renewable energy integration, and improve the reliability and quality of electricity services.

Minister for Energy Resources C.T.R. Nirmalkumar exchanged the MoU with Manu Santhanam, Dean of Industrial Consultancy and Sponsored Research, IIT Madras, in the presence of TNPDCL Chairman and Managing Director J. Radhakrishnan and IIT Madras Director V. Kamakoti, at a function held at the TNPDCL headquarters here on Thursday.

The MoU aims to introduce innovative technologies across power generation, transmission, and distribution sectors

Mr. Nirmalkumar said it would help upgrade the State's power sector to global standards and pave the way for long-term collaboration with scientists of the premier institute. The MoU aims at introducing innovative technologies across power generation, transmission, distribution, and green energy sectors.

The programme will help set up a research and development centre and implement artificial intelligence, along with machine learning and data analytics, for data-driven decision-making processes.

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A perfect storm

A combination of natural calamity and human failure laid Wayanad low

The fragile hills of Kerala's Wayanad district turned into the theatre of yet another weather-induced disaster when a heavy downpour, on July 7, triggered what looked like a debris slide at the entrance to the under-construction twin tunnel at Kalladi in Meppadi panchayat, in the vicinity of Chooralmala, which was wrecked by massive landslides two years ago. Six workers were confirmed dead. The Kerala government has suspended construction work until the completion of a comprehensive probe into the causes and whether the work complied with the conditions set by the Expert Appraisal Committee under the Union Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change (MoEFCC) while granting environmental clearance for the project. Ever since the great floods of 2018, Mep-padi panchayat, which is over 7,000 ft above sea level, has witnessed severe climate-induced ca-tastrophes. Landslides hit the Puthumala area in 2019, within hours of an equally lethal landslide across the hills in Kavalappara in Malappuram district. Environmentalists, therefore, made an impassioned plea against the ₹2,100 crore (ap-proximately) 8.73-km-long twin-tube tunnel road, linking Anakkampoyil in Kozhikode to Mep-padi, flagging it as a recipe for disaster. It was in-stead fast-tracked, citing the need for accelerated mobility for the people of Wayanad, which does not have tertiary care facilities. In April this year, the Supreme Court cited the project's 'national importance' and rejected the Wayanad Prakrithi Samrakshana Samithi's plea to halt it. The group is planning to seek a review of the order.

As with all major disasters, this, too, appears to have stemmed from a heady mix of failures. Kerala Public Works Minister hurriedly pointed to the company executing the construction on behalf of the contractor, Konkan Railways, alleg-ing that it ignored the department's June 20 dea-dline to remove excavation debris from the area. The company fell back on the rainfall data and the region's landslide susceptibility. Security camera visuals suggest an avalanche-like flow of debris down the slope of the hill that was being bored. Whether a mudslip in the upper reaches caused the debris to cascade down will only be known after a geomorphological probe. On the face of it, the State's disaster management ma-chinery was not up to the job. The synoptic con-ditions in the area on the eve of the present disas-ter were eerily similar to those on the eve of the 2024 calamity. Wayanad has a fragile ecology, and any infrastructure project must involve met-iculous ecological and climate-resilience plan-ning and uncompromising execution. As it in-vestigates the lapses, the State should review the project's social and environmental costs and en-sure that climate-induced catastrophe in Waya-nad is prevented, not just responded to.

Far from over

Iran and the U.S. must address the trust deficit for their talks to progress

It took only 20 days for the U.S.-Iran memo-randum of understanding (MoU), which promised to extend the ceasefire by 60 days and launch talks about outstanding issues, in-cluding Iran's nuclear programme, to start unra-velling. On Tuesday night, the U.S. carried out sweeping air strikes in Iran after three tankers were attacked in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran struck American bases in Kuwait and Bahrain after which Mr. Trump declared that the ceasefire was over. While he is known for making exaggerated claims, the current crisis poses the biggest chal-lenge to the peace process since the June 17 MoU. The crisis did not emerge overnight. From the outset, the agreement had three major sticking points – Israel's war in Lebanon; Iran's access to its frozen funds and the status of the Strait of Hor-muz. Tehran sees Israel's refusal to withdraw from southern Lebanon, along with Washing-ton's push for a parallel trilateral framework in-volving the U.S., Lebanon and Israel, as violations of the spirit of the MoU. And, despite talks, Iran has yet to get access to its frozen funds. Finally, Iran appears determined to assert control over the Strait. It has opened a "safe passage route" along its coast, while the U.S. is backing an al-ternative route along Oman's coast.

Iran fears that the U.S. is trying to strip away the leverage it established over the Strait during the war by promoting an alternative route. The U.S. does not want Iran to emerge as the sole cus-todian of a strategic waterway. These conflicting positions trigger skirmishes, further undermin-ing the MoU. What Mr. Trump, who senses strat-egic defeat, is trying to do is to mount economic and military pressure on Tehran to change its po-sition on the Strait. He can continue his air cam-paign, but his years-long maximum pressure and 40 days of bombing have done little to alter Iran's negotiating positions. If he returns to war over Hormuz, Iran's stance on its nuclear programme – still unaddressed – would only get hardened. If war resumes, it would be bad news for the whole West Asia region and the entire global economy. Mr. Trump is at a strategic dead end, and instead of digging deeper, should stick to his way-out road map – the MoU. An obstacle in the peace process is the complete absence of trust. Mr. Trump's public tirades and abuses against Iran's leadership and hyperbolic threats, which are de-tached from ground realities, are not helping his cause. Equally, if Iran continues targeting com-mercial vessels, it risks being seen as an aggressor rather than a victim. Both sides should address the trust deficit, resolve the sticking points in the MoU and begin serious talks about the outstand-ing issues for a final settlement.

Manipur is one of the States covered under Phase III of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls being implemented by the Election Commission of India (ECI) currently. The SIR has already drawn adverse criticism from civil society organisations and the Opposition, particularly after the recent Bihar and West Bengal elections, due to its hasty, disproportionate and summary deletion of voters from voters' lists, resulting in the disenfranchisement of large sections of politically "undesirable" communities and voters. Concerns have been expressed by informed citizens about the lack of transparency and often blatant bias of the State and the ruling party in relation to the SIR, and its relationship with the planned delimitation, the 2029 elections and perhaps even an oddly timed Census. These concerns apply to Manipur as well. In addition, there are features of the situation in Manipur that are little known outside – and even within – the State, making the implementation of the SIR in Manipur even more egregious.

Fractured social fabric

First, Manipur has been in the throes of an intense ethnic conflict involving the majority Meiteis (54% of the population, inhabiting the dense Imphal Valley), the Kuki-Zo peoples (15%, inhabiting the surrounding hills) and, more recently, the Manipuri Nagas (26%, mainly in the northern part of Manipur). It has resulted in over 260 deaths in pogroms, attacks, and retaliatory violence; displaced some 60,000 people within and outside Manipur; led to the burning of hundreds of villages and places of worship; and witnessed unimaginable atrocities, including beheadings, dismemberment, and rapes as forms of collective punishment, disproportionately inflicted on the Kuki-Zo.

It has led to a demand by the Kuki-Zo for a 'Separate Administration' for themselves – and an equally stout opposition by the Meiteis to it – while many Manipuri Nagas led by the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (Isak-Muivah), or NSCN-IM, remain committed to their decades old demand for integration of Naga-inhabited areas in a sovereign 'Nagalim'. Many are backed by political, militant and proscribed insurgent groups of diverse persuasions.

Three years after the start of the conflict, not a single case of violence has been brought to book through the courts. An Inquiry Commission



Gautam Mukhopadhyaya

Former Ambassador of India to Myanmar, Afghanistan and Syria, and engaged in issues facing the northeast of India

Manipur's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls risks deepening exclusion amid ethnic conflict, displacement, and identity challenges

formed by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has yet to present its report. Thousands of internally displaced persons languish in camps with little relief.

Ethnic divisions have worsened and spread. Long-standing Naga-Kuki hostilities have been added to the three-year-old Meitei-Kuki conflict marked by the burning of villages (mostly Kuki), ambushes, and recently in May, the killing of three Thadou-Kuki pastors, and, in retaliation, tit-for-tat hostage-taking and the horrific killing of six Nagas in Kuki custody that has in turn set off a full economic blockade of Kangpokpi district. In response, State and central security forces have appeared passive, paralysed and at times, biased.

The conduct of the State government has been widely viewed as partisan, but the role of the Centre and even courts cannot be said to be above board. Conducting the SIR under these conditions, under a pretence of normalcy, is inexplicable.

Narratives driving electoral exclusion

Second, unlike the rest of the country, where the SIR is being driven by the central government through the ECI with the partisan support of the ruling party, in Manipur the demand to "cleanse" the State of alleged "illegal migrants" – a code word for Kukis – is in line with perceptions of politically radicalised Meiteis and Manipuri Nagas, who together constitute about 80% of the population. These allegations have no basis in Census figures for over a century, and are based on recent distortions of history, fake narratives and loud propaganda that feed directly into the SIR exercise. They create a very negative environment for a fair SIR, particularly in mixed areas, that is itself, *ipso facto*, biased against certain communities.

Third, there are several features peculiar to the Kukis themselves that lend themselves to their victimisation by the SIR. The first reason is that close to 50,000 Kuki-Zo remain displaced and scattered in Manipur and outside. There does not seem to be any provision in place for their fair enumeration.

The second reason is that together with their displacement, many are known to have lost many of their identity, residence, election, education and other documents that could have helped establish their voter credentials. There are visual records of Kuki-Zo educational certificates, Aadhaar cards, and driving licences in Imphal being destroyed after the violence of May 2023.

Building a durable India-Australia partnership



Shruti Pandalai

Inaugural India Chair at The Lowy Institute, Sydney, Australia

Indian Coast Guard and adopts an India-Australia Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap to address shared threat perceptions. These are practical mechanisms that deepen interoperability without altering the basic character of the relationship: India remains a trusted security partner, not an ally. On energy security, Australian uranium has been legally available to India since the bilateral 2014 civil nuclear agreement, but it never actually moved commercially, largely because India's own nuclear liability law made foreign suppliers nervous about exposure.

That changed with the SHANTI Act last December, which reformed that liability regime. The agreement on uranium has operationalised a deal lying dormant for a decade. The summit also launched the Australia-India Partnership on Cyber, Critical Technologies and Supply Chains (PACTS), while reaffirming the complementarity to the Australia-Canada-India Technology and Innovation Partnership as focusing on building resilient technology partnerships through flexible minilateral arrangements. These are examples of alignment beginning to take institutional form.

There are focus areas, there are problems

But for alignment to be durable, convergence must translate into operational overlap. This is most consequential in the Indian Ocean, a region where Australian and Indian interests overlap most naturally. Both are Indian Ocean states with real stakes in the region's sea lanes. India's Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region has emerged as a key hub for maritime domain awareness, even as Australia pays closer attention to its western seaboard and Indian Ocean approaches. The two navies have converged on similar risk assessments of shadow fleets, threats to undersea cables and coercive activity below the threshold of conflict.

The new Coast Guard MoU and Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap narrow the gap between strategic intent and operational cooperation. Yet, Australia's most consequential force-structure decisions, from AUKUS (trilateral security partnership between Australia, the United Kingdom, and the U.S.) to its broader defence posture, remain oriented towards the Western Pacific, while India's strategic planners continue to divide attention between continental threats and maritime challenges. The shared ground is real; it is simply narrower than the political convergence sometimes suggests.

Economically, the pattern is similar. Trade has

The third reason is that customary naming systems – where names are derived from the last syllable of complex parental names, nicknames often substitute formal names, and names are converted from tribal names to English orthography – create vast scope "logical discrepancies", making people far more vulnerable to exclusion than in States such as West Bengal. Possibly, more than 90% of Kuki-Zo people are unlikely to be able to produce a single, consistent spelling of their own names, let alone maintain consistency across generations.

The fourth reason is that by some historical anomaly, Manipuri tribals, both Kuki-Zo and Naga, do not enjoy Sixth Schedule status, although they enjoy some measure of autonomy under Article 371C and very weak Autonomous Councils.

This served them well during periodic bouts of violence and displacement, most recently during the Naga-Kuki violence of the 1990s, which again disproportionately affected the Kukis. Village chiefs and local authorities were then able to certify the identities of villagers under their jurisdiction. Such arrangements are unlikely to be recognised in the present exercise and prevailing atmosphere.

Finally, the Kuki-Zo leadership appears, for some reason, unaware of the nature, motivations, and implications of the SIR exercise. They seem to believe, perhaps naively, that as Indian citizens who have lived here all their lives and in possession of necessary documents, including voter ID cards, they have nothing to fear, and that opposing the exercise would amount to an admission of guilt. The dangers of the SIR now appear to be dawning on them, with some Kuki-Zo civil society organisations issuing statements highlighting its shortcomings, although opposition has yet to take a political form.

Safeguarding belonging

A nationwide SIR is now a *fait accompli* following the ruling by the Supreme Court of India in its favour. However, the process can still be made fairer and more sensitive to the risks of exclusion. Unless measures are adopted to limit its potential harm, by 2029 we may see a pathway to statelessness not only for the Kuki-Zo but also for other tribal communities in the Northeast, with their plight obscured amid the broader exclusion and disenfranchisement of Muslims labelled as "illegal migrants".

grown sharply since the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement came into force, but industry voices behind closed doors argue that growth sits disproportionately with large firms. Smaller exporters on both sides remain unaware of how to use it. Track 1.5 dialogues have flagged this as an operationalisation gap.

The knowledge deficit is more obvious when one looks at Australian public consciousness on India. This year's Lowy Poll found only 5% of Australians expect India to be the world's most important power a decade from now, against 54% for China, even as trust in India remains comparatively high. Convergence at the top has not yet trickled down into wider awareness of India's strategic heft.

The diaspora opportunity

The diaspora remains the biggest opportunity to change this, but with a caveat. Indian-origin Australians are now the country's largest immigrant-born community, ahead of the U.K.-born population for the first time. Political leadership has celebrated the diaspora's contribution, and a Centre for Australia-India Relations study finds that Australians broadly recognise it as skilled migrants, students and workers. But recognising the diaspora as a cultural asset, or an electoral constituency, is not alignment. Alignment would require translating that diaspora leverage into a public case for why India matters economically to the average Australian. It would require institutionalising the diaspora's comparative advantage in helping Australian Small and Medium-sized Enterprises navigate Indian regulatory and business culture, and vice versa, rather than leaving that work to individual champions. It would also mean untangling the mobility of Indian professionals from Australia's increasingly fraught migration politics.

Mr. Modi's visit has provided fresh ballast for these conversations about the future of the India-Australia partnership. His message on Australian Pension funds investing in India particularly resonated in the room when he said India would not just treat them as capital but as a marker of strategic trust imposed by Australian families in India. These statements matter because they build the broader public consciousness of India as a trusted partner for the future. Convergence got India and Australia to the table; it is these steps that institutionalise engagement incrementally that build alignment that endures.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trump's truce flips

It is deplorable that the much-hyped ceasefire agreement between Iran and the U.S. is already fizzling out, signalling prolonged military hostilities in the war-ravaged region. It is

equally baffling that the United Nations has remained a silent spectator to the cascading effects of the conflict in West Asia. This only goes to show that peace accords brokered by regional non-state actors are unlikely to foster a

durable ceasefire.
G. Ramasubramanyam,
Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh

Students' personal data

The reported sale of CUET and NEET candidates' databases by websites is a serious violation of

students' privacy and a blatant breach of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act. Personal information collected for examinations must never be commercialised without explicit consent. This illegal trade exposes students to

spam, fraud, identity theft, and exploitation by coaching institutes and admission agents. The authorities must investigate these websites and impose stringent penalties. The National Testing Agency and the Government must

strengthen data security measures to restore confidence in the examination system.
Bhushan Manchanda,
New Delhi

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should India restart dialogue with Pakistan?



Mani Shankar Aiyar

Former Member of Parliament



Tara Kartha

Former Director at the National Security Council Secretariat

PARLEY

India and Pakistan have not engaged in dialogue since 2016 when talks broke down after the terror attacks at Pathankot and subsequently at Uri. The last 12 years have witnessed major attacks at Pahalgam (2025) and Pulwama (2019) and that apart, there were several smaller terror attacks. Earlier this month, a group of eminent citizens led by Gandhian O.P. Shah drafted a joint appeal to the leaders of India and Pakistan urging them to engage in dialogue. This has led to a public debate on whether India should restart dialogue with Pakistan. Mani Shankar Aiyar, who was a signatory to the letter, and Tara Kartha discuss the question in a conversation moderated by Kallol Bhattacharjee. Edited excerpts:

Should India and Pakistan restart dialogue at this moment, especially since they haven’t spoken to each other at the government level for a decade now?

Mani Shankar Aiyar: It is precisely for that very reason, because we haven’t spoken to each other for the best part of the last 12 years, that it is absolutely necessary that we resume the dialogue as soon as possible. And as regards the time, my own view is that any time is as good as any other time. And all times when we don’t talk are bad for both of us. So I would urge the governments to talk to each other. And until they do, I think people of goodwill on either side of our border should be in touch with each other. I speak as somebody with nearly 40 years of experience of Pakistan and Pakistanis. I have been through several different Pakistani regimes, and it does not seem to me that it matters who is in power in Pakistan. When we engage with them, we engage with Pakistan, and not with a particular individual.

Tara Kartha: Ideally both countries should talk to each other because they are nuclear powers. These are dangerous times, especially since there was an active phase of hostility last year. But my problem is that the present leadership is basically Field Marshal Asim Munir. Let us forget about Shehbaz Sharif [the Prime Minister of Pakistan], for as much as I regard him, I’m sure he is a fine and good politician in his own right, Mr. Munir is in power and he’s even more powerful than General Pervez Musharraf was before him. He holds absolute power; him and a couple of core commanders, such as his ISI (Inter-Services Intelligence) chief. It is very important to understand that the rise of Field Marshal Munir began in a very systematic fashion once they carried out the terror strike in Pahalgam. I won’t say after Operation Sindoor;



Tense ties: Army soldiers patrol along the Line of Control between Pakistan and India in the Uri Sector, Jammu and Kashmir in January. IMRAN NISSAR

I’ll say after the Pahalgam attack.

I agree with Mr. Aiyar that it doesn’t matter who you talk to, provided that person is interested in peace. But the question is, what stake does Field Marshal Munir have in peace? In that case, he’ll have to step down for a civilian prime minister. The moment things get peaceful, they’ll tell the Pakistan military to go back to the barracks and that the civilians will take over. So why should he [be interested in peace]? It is a systemic issue. I’m not saying the army can never be talked to. This particular man will not. He is very dangerous.

Is it the correct time to go ahead with the dialogue with Pakistan?

MSA: If we don’t go ahead, we’ll be stuck in the rut in which we are today. There was a mention of one man, Asim Munir, who’s been in power for approximately one year. But we haven’t talked to Pakistan for 12 years. So I don’t see how Asim Munir being there is the biggest obstacle. We could have talked to Nawaz Sharif. We could have talked to Imran Khan. We could have talked to several others.

And if you look at the past, we have had extremely fruitful talks with Pakistani generals but rarely with Pakistani civilians. Let me first



We are currently talking to Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu who has been indicted by the ICC for war crimes. If we can talk to every dictator around the world, what’s the problem in talking to the people next door who have the misfortune of being led by an army commander?

MANI SHANKAR AIYAR

run through the Pakistani army men with whom we have had successful interlocations. Ayub Khan was the one who broke the deadlock on the Indus Waters Treaty. It was Zia-ul-Haq who broke the deadlock on Siachen. It was Musharraf, who broke the deadlock on what till then was projected as the single biggest obstacle in India-Pakistan relations, namely the Kashmir question; they arrived at a four-point solution. However, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto signed on the dotted line in Simla and then turned his back on it.

This is a false argument – that just because the Pakistani army is in power we can’t talk to them. We are currently talking to Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu who has been indicted by the International Criminal Court (ICC) for war crimes. If we can talk to every dictator around the world, including army dictators, what’s the problem in talking to the people next door who have the misfortune of being led by an army commander?

So, the argument is that if the Government of India is in dialogue with several military dictators, then why should it not consider talking to Pakistan led by a military general?

TK: As someone who has been in the security establishment, my problem is how do I deal with terrorism? If a democratically elected government opens the door for dialogue and then gets hit by a terror attack – then the question is how to deal with terror attacks that disrupt dialogue? As a democratically elected government, can you justify dialogue? This is a point that was asked by even Nawaz Sharif who said that a terror attack takes place each time dialogue is attempted.

However, I will agree that a few military generals have shown remarkable good sense. In the recent past, when a BrahMos missile was accidentally fired at Pakistan, the Pakistan army handled it well. While the civilians protested, the Pakistan army took it in their stride and kept quiet. At the moment I am concerned with the timing of this proposal as Mr. Munir is in power. The other issue is that Pakistan is in chaos as

there are daily incidents that are being reported in various parts of the country. It’s in chaos. So right now he wants to talk. He may have every incentive to talk. Why should I talk? If there is even one indication from Pakistan that they are going to close down terrorist camps, I’m sure tomorrow the government will be ready to talk.

But if at all we are to go forward, I would like to see, for example, a talk on climate change. We are both countries that are equally in bad shape when it comes to climate vulnerabilities. I would like a talk on air pollution, as during a particular season of the year, both sides start burning crop residues triggering an environmental crisis. That kind of a functional dialogue, which does not involve any territorial issue, no vested or political interests is purely functional and people-centric.

I find the kind of wishful thinking which one sees in the letter as a little idealistic. It’s a bit over the top.

Does the current Indian government have the political bandwidth to talk to the Pakistani establishment?

MSA: Talking to them doesn’t mean bending our knees before them. If you have the courage to undertake surgical strikes against them, why don’t you have the courage to sit across a table and talk to them? That’s my simple point. And if you won’t do so, as I’m talking to the Government of India, then we will. We’ve got Zoom. But I am going to talk to my numerous friends in Pakistan. The number of my friends in Pakistan is larger than the number of enemies I have in India. And that’s a rather large number.

TK: Before Prime Minister Narendra Modi, we had someone like Atal Bihari Vajpayee who put his career on the line and went to Lahore. Prime Minister Modi tried in 2015 and went to meet Nawaz Sharif and extended an olive branch. But all these have a political cost.

The question is what will we ask of them. If we have a dialogue tomorrow, we will ask them to stop exporting terrorism and they, in turn, will accuse us of doing things in Balochistan etc. whereas the Baloch people have been harassed since 1947. The question is what can India do in terms of the protests happening in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK). We should talk to Pakistan if General Munir shows some evidence that he is cutting down on terrorism.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

How a city’s working class is driven to the margins and made invisible

The workers who collect garbage and keep our cities clean, and the workers who commute via cycles deserve recognition and respect

Suruchi Kumari

Before a story is to take shape through conversations with a part of the city’s population, which the city itself only passively interacts with, it is discussed in a Monday pitch meeting where reporters and editors sit. Once approved, a familiar question follows – “Where will we find these people?”

I encountered this question before working on two separate stories on informal waste workers, and workers who commute by cycle. In both cases, the question did not hold for long. What first sounded like an inquiry about access, over the course of the reporting, began to feel like an assumption that these people are difficult to locate; almost external to the city.

For ‘finding’ people who cycle to work in Delhi, I reached out to Professor Rahul Goel from IIT Delhi, whose work over the years has focused on commuting patterns and mobility. When I asked him, “Where will I find them?”, he directed me to the city’s busiest intersections, where roads from the peripheries meet industrial areas and affluent localities, where many of them work as daily wage labourers, security guards, and helpers.

I met Sandeep at one of those busy intersections on a humid April evening, when he was returning home from his sales job. Aged 23, he had been working for eight years. The break from school to contribute to his household became permanent after COVID-19 hit. Before getting back on his bicycle to ride 8 kilometres more, he said, “*Humlog dikhte nahi hain* (We are invisible).” He said that a cycling network sounds like a fantasy in a city that still doesn’t have footpaths everywhere. The draft Master Plan of Delhi 2041 notes that this “unequal distribution of roads” makes it non-conducive for cycling.

By the time I filed the story, curiosity had begun to feel like ignorance. I started seeing cyclists everywhere – at every intersection, at every signal. They kept to the kerb, and when traffic swelled, even that space was taken over as motorists pushed

forward to gain ground. A car owner I spoke to said, “They slow the traffic down, such a nuisance.” Cyclists are registered only when their presence creates friction.

Similarly, a waste picker becomes visible only when their access to gated colonies is debated. Most residents encounter them every day. They collect garbage from homes and do the work that reduces the burden on municipal systems without formal recognition or integration into the waste economy. They continue to speak of restricted access, allegations of theft, and the absence of dedicated workspaces.

To write about the workforce that sorts much of the city’s waste in March, I first travelled to a *jhuggi* cluster in Bhalswa, in northwest Delhi, a few kilometres from the towering landfill. Days later, while walking to a Metro station in south Delhi, I noticed a large sack of waste stacked beside a road, similar to the one I had seen in Bhalswa. It led me to a corner of my own neighbourhood that I realised I had never seen before. There, too, people were sorting waste sharing similar stories of migration and precarious work. By the time I finished the story, I had met waste workers across the city. Sameer Ali, whom I had never seen before January, moved in the same lanes around 9 pm with his bicycle cart carrying a stack of cardboard. People that our stories set out to look for, unlike responses from government authorities, are not hard to find. They are everywhere, for all to see.

It is tempting to think invisibility is simply a failure to notice. But invisibility is rarely accidental. When a city invests heavily in roads for cars while cycling infrastructure remains largely absent, cyclists do not disappear. A worker rehabilitated to the margins of Delhi, 40-50 kilometres away from the place where she works, is moved away from the corridors of visibility so that her problems with transport or healthcare become easier to overlook.

These workers state that recognition in government policies would give them a life of dignity and respect.

suruchi.kumari@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Pilgrims’ progress



Stormy route: The first batch of pilgrims on the annual Amarnath Yatra cross mountain trails amid rainfall during their journey to the Amarnath cave on the Baltal route, northeast of Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir on July 3. The yatra was almost cancelled due to unpredictable mountain weather, but it resumed again. THE HINDU

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 10, 1976

Eminent scientists’ club suggested

New Delhi, July 9: A proposal to establish a club of eminent scientists from the non-aligned developing countries for making futuristic studies of the development pattern of the Third World is being mooted by some top scientists here.

According to informed sources, the idea is to set up an institution like the “Club of Rome” where eminent scientists from the developing non-aligned countries could continuously



study problems concerning the Third World and projections of growth in various fields such as economic development, population, agriculture and technology.

There is a feeling among scientists in developing countries that projections made by prestigious groups like the “Club of Rome” often tend to ignore realities in the developing countries as they, being supported by the developed countries, look at the problems of developing countries from the perspectives of the developed countries. Some of the projections made by the “Club of Rome” set up with financial support from the developed countries on the pattern of growth and development in the world, are being hotly contested by scientists of the Third World.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 10, 1926

The mission of poets

Calcutta, July 9: “The Mission of Poets” was the subject of an interesting lecture, delivered by Mrs. Sarojini Naidu, to-day, at the instance of the Poetry Society. Mrs. Naidu delivered an inspiring address in the course of which she said she would like to destroy all printing presses that printed poetry and to leave it at the mercy of all learned professors to teach the young how to paraphrase, analyse, interpret, and scan poetry. A poet knows that he is not more than a mirror of these intimate secrets of the human heart of which the heart itself is so often unaware.

NDA-ruled States, universities object to centralisation provisions in VBSA

Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya among States to raise concerns over the Centre's powers; universities seek safeguards, parliamentary monitoring; BHU warns that Bill could turn an independent regulator into arm of the Union govt.

Sobhana K. Nair
Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

NDA-ruled States, including Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Meghalaya, have raised concerns over provisions in the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025, warning a parliamentary panel that the proposed legislation would centralise powers over higher education regulation.

The Bill proposes a structural overhaul of higher education in the country, by repealing the statutory Acts governing the University Grants Commission (UGC), the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), and the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE) and replacing them with a single apex body called the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA).

The Bill is currently under review by a joint parliamentary committee headed by BJP MP D. Purandeswari. *The Hindu* accessed submissions made to the parliamentary panel, which is in the final stages of preparing its report.

Apart from State governments, Central and State universities and institutes have also criticised the Bill, raising concerns over the Centre's expanded powers, the absence of State representation in the proposed regulatory structure, ambiguities in its scope, and the transition process following the winding up of the UGC,



The Bill proposes an overhaul of higher education by repealing the statutory Acts governing the UGC, the AICTE, and the NCTE and replacing them with a single apex body. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

AICTE, and NCTE.

Bypassing States

Some of the strongest objections came from Andhra Pradesh, which is ruled by the Telugu Desam Party, a BJP ally. The State argued that several provisions of the Bill could render its legislative authority over higher education “a dead letter” and sought mandatory consultation before decisions affecting State universities are taken. The State also cautioned against Clause 11 that allows the Regulatory Council to bypass State universities in granting degrees, saying it could lead to “constitutional friction”.

The State government further suggested a clause explicitly preventing the Centre from taking action prejudicial to the autonomy, functioning, and governance of State institutes and universities.

BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh has also raised concerns over what it de-

scribed as limited State representation in the proposed regulatory council.

The Meghalaya government – led by the National People's Party, which is a BJP ally – recommended an explicit provision defining the respective powers of the Centre and the States. It proposed that the Centre be responsible for coordination, standards, accreditation, and quality assurance, while States retain authority over the establishment, governance, administration, staffing, financing, and overall functioning of State universities.

Key vulnerability

Central universities and institutes such as the Banaras Hindu University (BHU), the Central University of Rajasthan and the Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIIT), Chittoor, as well as State universities in Assam, Maharashtra, and Jammu and Kashmir, have objected to

provisions that they say could increase centralisation.

Several institutions told the panel that clauses requiring the new regulatory structure to follow directions from the Centre represented the Bill's “most critical vulnerability”.

While some universities cautioned that dismantling the UGC, AICTE, and NCTE simultaneously could cause “significant institutional disruption”, others argued that the Bill concentrated regulatory powers and created the possibility of “arbitrary interventions”. Institutions called for phased implementation, parliamentary oversight of powers exercised by the Centre under the Bill, and mandatory notice and consultation with States before such powers are invoked.

BHU noted that Clause 45 gives finality to the Centre's policy directions and binds the VBSA to them, “effectively subordinating the regulator to the executive”, while Clause 47 empowers the Centre to supersede the VBSA and dissolve it. The university told the panel that these provisions risked turning an independent regulator into “an arm of the government of the day”.

Clause 45 empowers the Centre to issue binding policy directions to the Commission, gives it the final say on what constitutes a policy matter, and allows it to assign additional functions. Clause 47 allows the Centre to suspend or supersede the Commission or its councils for up to a

year. IIIT Chittoor said a possible implication of Clause 45 was the expansion of Centre's influence across the three councils proposed under the structure, which could end up shaping institutional academic operations. SNDT Women's University, Pune, said that without checks and balances, consultation and parliamentary oversight, the provisions could lead to “excessive centralisation”.

Fee escalation

Congress-ruled Telangana said the Bill's structure does not adequately recognise the role of State governments. It sought the deletion of Clause 11, which empowers the Union government-backed Regulatory Council to authorise independent accredited colleges to grant degrees directly, bypassing the State governments. It also argued that the Bill neither empowers the Regulatory Council to regulate fees nor preserves the existing framework, potentially allowing fee escalation.

Telangana's Higher Education Department described Clause 45 as the “single most centralising clause” in the Bill, calling it a “self-judging clause” that gives the Centre the final authority in disputes with councils under the VBSA framework.

The department argued that the provision expanded Central authority over the structure without granting States corresponding powers over matters relating to their own universities.

Cong. alleges forged gram sabha consent for Singrauli mining

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Vikrant Bhuria

Alleging that gram sabha consent for coal mining in Madhya Pradesh's Singrauli district had been obtained through forged resolutions carrying the thumb impressions of deceased persons, the Congress on Thursday demanded a CBI inquiry into what it called *angootha chori* (stealing thumb impressions). The party said the alleged fraud in tribal areas was part of a wider pattern of subversion of environmental and forest safeguards.

At a press conference in New Delhi, All India Congress Committee national coordinator for SC, OBC, Minority and Adivasi Departments K. Raju and Adivasi Congress chief Vikrant Bhuria alleged that fake gram sabha approvals had been used to facilitate mining in the Dhirauli coal block in Singrauli, where, they claimed, an Adani group-linked company was operating. There was no immediate response from the company or the administration.

Cites RTI documents

Mr. Bhuria cited RTI documents and death certificates to claim that the names and thumb impressions of persons who had died years earlier appeared in gram sabha resolutions shown as having been passed in 2021.

He referred to the cases of Brij Bhan Singh, who died in 2014 but was allegedly shown as having given consent in 2021; Phooleswari Singh, who died in 2018 but whose consent

was allegedly recorded three years later; and Jag Bandhan Singh Gond, who died in 2015 but whose thumb impression was allegedly used in 2021.

Mr. Bhuria also alleged that some living residents who were literate and ordinarily sign documents had their thumb impressions affixed instead. Such practices violated the Forest Rights Act and the Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, under which gram sabha consent was mandatory in Scheduled Areas before land could be acquired or forest land diverted, he said.

The Congress demanded a CBI probe into the alleged fraud, action against officials and companies involved, and a halt to mining activity in the area until the claims were independently verified.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh amplified the charge on social media, saying that after “*vote chori, seat chori* and *chanda chori*”, the country was now witnessing “*angootha chori*”. In a separate post, he widened the attack on the Narendra Modi government and targeted Union Environment Minister Bhopender Yadav over the abrupt removal of four of his close aides.

UGC-NET leak claims spark Congress call to scrap NTA

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday intensified its attack on the Union government over alleged irregularities in the UGC-NET, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and the disbanding of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

The Opposition party's attack came after allegations surfaced that the Sociology paper in the UGC-NET held on June 30 had been leaked.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh, sharing a media report on social media platform X, said the alleged leak had exposed the hollowness of the government's claim that shifting examinations to a computer-based test (CBT) format would curb malpractice.

“Days after the NEET-UG exam was leaked in May 2026, ‘Mantri Pradhan’ announced that NEET would be conducted in CBT mode from next year, implicitly suggesting that a computer-based examination could not be leaked,” Mr. Ramesh said. “Now there are reports that the UGC-NET Sociology examination appears to have been leaked despite being a CBT,” he added.

He also referred to earlier complaints regarding the UGC-NET English examination, in which questions were allegedly lifted from past papers without change, and charged that the problem lay not in the mode of examination but in a “compromised” Education Ministry and a “deliberately incompetent and incapacitated” NTA.

‘Champat Rai not upset about his resignation’

Press Trust of India
AYODHYA

Ram temple trust treasurer Govind Dev Giri on Thursday said Champat Rai is not upset after resigning as its general secretary in the wake of the alleged donation theft and is fully supportive of the new temple management system being put in place.

“I met Champat Rai ji yesterday mainly to check on his health. He is healthy, solution-oriented and has no misgivings about his resignation,” Mr. Giri said. “He (Champat) is an old veteran who has devoted his life to the country. He is fully supportive of the new (temple management) system being put in place and he isn't upset or angry,” he said.

Examine call records of Ram Temple employees: Akhilesh

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Upping the ante on the Ram Temple donations issue, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday demanded that the call detail records of all those employed in the temple be examined, claiming that 99.9% of them would have links with the BJP.

Talking to reporters here, Mr. Yadav also accused the BJP of placing electoral considerations above religious values.

“All the call detail records (CDR) of those who were working in the temple complex should be examined. The moment the CDRs are scrutinised, 99.9% of them will turn out to be BJP people. You cannot imagine the turmoil that will break out within the BJP then. The exodus



Akhilesh Yadav

has already begun and many people have already started contacting us,” he claimed.

Raising queries over the functioning of the SIT, the former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister said: “What SIT is this? It is merely an attempt to cover up the matter. Who constituted this SIT? We are also hearing that questions have been raised about the SIT itself. One of its members is fac-

ing a cheating case. Tell me, will such a person continue to be part of the SIT?”

The SIT comprising Divisional Commissioner of Lucknow Vijay Vishwas Pant, Inspector-General of Police S. Kiran and Special Secretary (Finance) Neel Ratan was constituted on June 13 to probe the donation theft allegations.

He also alleged that the BJP changes its ideology according to electoral convenience. Later in the day, he said in a post on X: “Only resignation will not do. The entire Trust should be dissolved.” He also demanded a judicial probe into “all land deals and other works carried out under the signatures of those who have resigned”, asserting that “resignation should not become a route to escape scrutiny”.

BJP nominates 3 ex-Trinamool MPs to RS hours after joining the party

Shiv Sahav Singh
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party on Thursday nominated three former Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MPs Sushmita Dev, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray and Prakash Chik Baraik to the Upper House of Parliament.

The development came hours after the three leaders joined the BJP in Kolkata. BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya welcomed the three former MPs by handing over a BJP flag to them at the party office.

Incidentally, Ms. Dev, Mr. Ray and Mr. Baraik joined the party days ahead of the July 24 bypolls to three Rajya Sabha seats in the State.

After the defeat of the Trinamool Congress in the



Former Trinamool Congress MPs Sushmita Dev, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray and Prakash Chik Baraik upon joining the BJP on Thursday. ANI

West Bengal Assembly polls, the three Rajya Sabha MPs who were nominated by party chairperson Mamata Banerjee had quit as members of the Upper House.

‘Accept wholeheartedly’

“The three former MPs have taken a stand and resigned from Rajya Sabha. It is a moment of happiness

for us. We accept the three of them wholeheartedly,” Mr. Bhattacharya said in the presence of the three leaders joining the BJP.

As the BJP has 208 legislators in the 294-member West Bengal Assembly, and the Trinamool Congress legislators are divided into two camps, their election is just a matter of time.

Earlier in the day, Ms.

Dev, a prominent leader from Assam, who left the Congress to join the Trinamool Congress in 2021, said that the BJP was a national party and the party's high command would take a call on her nomination to the Rajya Sabha.

Mr. Ray, a three-term Rajya Sabha member and former party chief whip who was one of Mamata Banerjee's key parliamentary faces, resigned from the Rajya Sabha and as a member of the party after Trinamool lost power in West Bengal.

Mr. Ray had met Home Minister Amit Shah during the latter's recent visit to Kolkata.

Mr. Baraik, who hails from Alipurduar, was nominated by Trinamool Congress to the Rajya Sabha in 2023.

Prashant Kishor has task cut out in Bankipur bypoll

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Ahead of the byelection in the Bankipur Assembly constituency in Patna, residents say the contest this time will be between the Bharatiya Janata Party candidate and Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor. Mr. Kishor has been busy in the constituency, addressing *nukkad* (corner) meetings and going door to door to meet people.

The byelection will be held on July 30 and the result will be out on August 3. The seat fell vacant after sitting BJP MLA Nitin Nabin was elected to the Rajya Sabha after being

named as the party's national president. Mr. Nabin had won five consecutive times from Bankipur, which has been a BJP stronghold. The party has fielded a young leader, Abhishek Kumar Sinha ‘Bunty’, while the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal has repeated its candidate, Rekha Gupta. In the 2025 Assembly election, Mr. Nabin had received 98,299 votes (62.66%) to defeat Ms. Gupta, who got 46,363 votes (29.55%). The JSP's Vandana Kumari had secured 7,717 votes (4.92%).

Both Mr. Abhishek and Mr. Gupta filed their nomination papers on Thursday and Mr. Kishor is expected to file his

BJP chief Nabin has won five consecutive times from Bankipur, which has been a BJP stronghold

nomination on July 11.

“For the past several Assembly elections, I've been voting for the BJP, but now it [the party] has become depressing. I will not vote for the BJP this time but the battle appears to be between Mr. Kishor and Mr. Abhishek,” said Suman Dhari Sinha, a septuagenarian resident of Kidwaiपुर locality in Bankipur. A few yards away from

his home, provision store owner Jyoti Kumar Verma, 50, asserted: “Only the BJP candidate will win. For the past nine Assembly elections [five terms for Mr. Nabin and four terms for his father Nabin Kishore Prasad Sinha], people of the constituency have reposed faith in the party's candidate... this time too, the candidate is local and personally knows everyone in the constituency... there is no match for the BJP.”

Batting for change

However, a young voter of the Dakshin Mandiri locality near Kathpul, Sumit Kumar, 29, asked, “We need change... for

how long will we keep voting for a single party?” He is unequivocal about who he thinks are the main contestants.

“The battle will be between Mr. Kishor and the Mr. Abhishek,” he said.

Bankipur is largely an urban constituency in central Patna with about 4 lakh voters and is dominated by Kayastha and Vaishya (trader) voters, besides a mixed population of other castes.

The BJP candidate is from the Kayastha community while the RJD candidate comes from the Vaishya community. Mr. Kishor belongs to the Brahmin community.

CJP urges students to join Parliament march on July 20

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party announced a peaceful march to Parliament on July 20, the first day of the Monsoon Session, on Thurs-

day. The CJP said the march would begin from Jantar Mantar. It called upon students, parents and citizens from across the country to join the march to seek justice for students and press for Mr. Pradhan's resignation.



TAMIL NADU AGRICULTURAL UNIVERSITY
COIMBATORE – 641 003
RATE CONTRACT NOTIFICATION – 2026-27

On behalf of Tamil Nadu Agricultural University, sealed tenders are invited for the supply of Chemicals, Laboratory apparatus, Scientific Equipments, Consumables, Glasswares - Fragile and Non-Fragile items etc., for the constituent Colleges, Departments, Research Stations, KVAFS and other Centres of the University during the financial year 2026-27. The firms should have three years of experience as on 01.01.2026 as “MANUFACTURER” of the said items, they intend to supply and hold a valid “Manufacturer's License” for such of those items which are marketed under their own approved or patented brand names or trademarks. The term “Manufacturer” also includes manufacturers or their sole agents or their dealer whom they authorize to participate in the tender. The Manufacturer should authorize only one dealer/distributor for participating in the tender. The tender documents can be obtained from the office of the Controller, Tamil Nadu Agricultural University, Coimbatore – 641003 on payment of cost of Rs.1770/- (Rs.1500/- + GST @18%) through a demand draft drawn in favour of the COMPTROLLER, TAMIL NADU AGRICULTURAL UNIVERSITY, COIMBATORE payable at State Bank of India, Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Branch, Coimbatore-3, subsequent to the date of publication of this notification. The last date for the issue of tender documents is 27.07.2026 upto 11.00 am. The last date for receipt of filled tenders is upto 4.00 pm on 27.07.2026. The tenders will be opened at 10.00 am on 28.07.2026. If the tender opening date happens to be a holiday, the tenders will be opened on the next working day.

DIPR/2256/Tender/2026

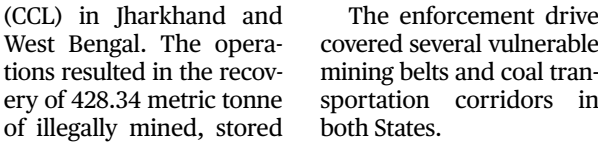
COMPTROLLER

An NDRF team on Thursday recovered a body from the debris of a building that collapsed at a waste management plant in Pimpri Chinchwad near Pune, officials said. Nine persons have been rescued so far in a multi-agency operation at the site, they said. A three-storey building located over a waste-to-energy plant at Moshi in the area collapsed after a huge mound of garbage crashed onto it on Wednesday afternoon, trapping around 18 individuals under the rubble. “We suspect that 7 to 8 people are still trapped under the debris,” a senior NDRF official said. PTI

Ms. Sengar, who gave birth on September 29 last year, submitted that she had volunteered for the requisite training, which was to commence on June 22 of this year. However, the department concerned had refused her permission, citing the Ministry's Office Memorandum of August 23, 1993, which provided for "a year's hiatus in training post delivery".

Boosting transparency

The CISF has launched intelligence-driven operations in coordination with Coal India subsidiaries, local police and district ad-



The department stated that the petitioners have not cited any law recognizing their relationship as a

The court is yet to pronounce its order on the matter.

In a related development, the Central Bureau of Investigation that is probing the Mahadev app-related corruption case, said on Thursday that it has filed a chargesheet against six accused and also filed additional evidence against "the main kingpins Saurabh Chandra and Ravi Uppal and

In January last year, a

They claim that the

“As the most searched and internationally recognised location in the State, any incorrect digital representation on a globally used platform has the potential to mislead users, and create unnecessary confusion regarding India’s territorial integrity,” Mr. Limboo said.

- 15 Small rest for golfers at New Scotland Yard for starters (6)
- 17 Look, covering a short length... An antelope! (7)
- 19 Sumatra tour results in sufferings (7)
- 22 Questioning, like royalty (6)
- 24 One moving in tummy gets protection (8)
- 26 Drug made from carotin processed with carbon (8)
- 28 Male with pointer gets food item that may be vegetarian or non-vegetarian (6)
- 30 Fish only (4)
- 31 Capital city is average in the beginning (5)
- 32 Bird seen in fernery (4)
- Down**
- 1 Keen to fracture joint (4)
- 2 Idiotic pal seen with East Asian people (8)
- 3 Virginia follows dancer Kelly in city (6)
- 4 Drink with actor's trainer (7)
- 5 Person who agrees, as despatched by queen (8)
- 6 Silver contained in home construction results in conductor's resistance (6)
- 7 Animal from Vishakapatnam area (4)
- 14 Devices to catch animals and rats running around top of pit (5)
- 15 Clever sting (5)
- 18 Graphic symbol from herpetology transliterated in her absence (8)
- 20 Frightened alien leaves Inland Revenue confused (8)
- 21 Sid rejected means of payment for shed (7)
- 23 "It's with Chinese editor" needed to be scratched (6)
- 25 Cocktail samosa Sam left after meeting Indian man at first (6)
- 27 Outer covering removed from samosa for prophet (4)
- 29 Has title to a portion of town square (4)

7	4	5	9	3	8	6	1	2
1	6	3	2	4	7	8	9	5
9	2	8	6	1	5	4	7	3
8	9	2	4	6	1	5	3	7
5	3	1	8	7	9	2	4	6
6	7	4	5	2	3	9	8	1
2	8	7	1	5	4	3	6	9
4	1	6	3	9	2	7	5	8
3	5	9	7	8	6	1	2	4

Anyone, regardless of their capacity to follow other paths, is eligible to perform *Saranaagathi* to achieve desired results. He emphasises that this path is open to all, including animals, birds and humans, as demonstrated by the Lord granting salvation to figures such as Jatayu (bird), cows (animal), cowherds, Nambaduvan, Brahmaraکشاشا and dadhibandan (curd pot), among others. Unlike Bhakthi Yoga, which is complicated and demands strict adherence to other methods, *Saranaagathi* is described as an easily practised, glorious method that requires no such prerequisites, other than deep and unshaken faith (*Mahaa Vivasanam*). The six parts of this practice are explained as: *Aanukoolya Sankalpam* (the resolve to be favourable to the Lord); *Prathikoolya Varjanam* (the avoidance of actions displeasing to the Lord); *Rakshishyathi iti visvaśaḥ*: (absolute faith that the Lord will protect); *Gopthruṭhva Varanam* (appealing to the Lord as the sole protector); *Kaarpanyam* (the humility of admitting one's utter helplessness); and finally, the sixth, which is offering one's soul, the responsibility of its protection, and the resulting fruits to the divine feet of the Lord.

INBRIEF



Govt. waives levy on key inputs for electronics manufacturing

The Centre has waived basic customs duty on goods used in manufacture of display assemblies, lithium ion cell and inductor coil module as it looks to promote domestic production of electronic devices like smartphones, laptops, wearables and smart TVs. The finance ministry issued three separate notifications giving effect to the basic customs duty (BCD) waiver on the goods used in manufacture of the three key components used in electronic devices. PTI

Adani to file sworn affidavit in U.S. court this week

Gautam Adani will file this week a sworn affidavit in a U.S. federal court stating whether he is aware of any promise, agreement or benefit linked to the U.S. government's decision to dismiss a criminal indictment against him. District Judge Nicholas Garaufis directed Mr. Adani to file the affidavit by July 15 before ruling on the Justice Department's motion to dismiss the indictment with prejudice. The Adani group did not offer any comment on the issue. PTI

Google appeals Indian ruling over its ads platform

Google has challenged an Indian court ruling that it infringed on a company's trademark rights by allowing rivals to use its name as an advertising keyword, arguing the decision will hurt consumers, documents reviewed by Reuters show. The May decision could reshape the online ads market in a country where Google last year earned \$4.1 billion in gross advertising revenue but where it is also facing a raft of antitrust cases and court battles. Google India's appeal will be heard in the coming days. REUTERS

Life insurers new business premium rises over 13% in June

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Life insurance companies in India reported new business premium rose 13% year-on-year in June to ₹46,490.53 crore. Market leader, State-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) posted muted NBP growth at ₹27,724.62 crore (₹27,395 crore). Private life insurers clocked ₹18,765.90 crore (₹13,722.29 crore). The number of policies/schemes sold by all the life insurers for June stood at 21,51,880 (20,06,322). For the quarter ended June, life insurers new business rose 16.60% to

₹1,09,071.75 crore. LIC logged new business of ₹65,548.88 crore, a 10.33% rise. Number of policies/schemes sold during Q1 was a tad over 2% more at 31,05,635. The private players, on a 12.68% rise in policies/schemes sold at 20,07,797, reported new business for Q1 climbed 27.51% to ₹43,522.87 crore. On June numbers, Emkay Research said while the protection segment saw continued growth momentum aided by GST rate exemption, the savings business was hit by geopolitical tensions stemming from the West Asia conflict and the overall macroeconomic situation.

Dr. Reddy's halts semaglutide supply on quality, shares slide, Torrent recalls product

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories said it halted commercial supplies of generic semaglutide after an issue with the active pharmaceutical ingredient (API) used in the drug and fresh despatches were likely only to towards late October or early November. "Certain batches of semaglutide were found to be out of specification due to an issue associated with the API. Until the issue is resolved, commercial supplies of the product will be delayed for a certain pe-

riod of time," DRL said. There is no impact on patient safety or on the product's global regulatory filings, the company said. Shares plunge The decision saw the firm's shares plunge almost 6% on the BSE. Meanwhile Torrent Pharmaceuticals announced a voluntary recall of select batches of Semalix injection disposable pens made by Dr. Reddy's on instructions from the latter. Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Novo Nordisk's blockbuster diabetes and weight loss drugs Wegovy and Ozem-

AI poses a relatively lower risk to India's GCC jobs: CEA

Nageswaran says most of India's Global Capability Centres are engaged in cutting-edge work rather than providing low-cost support, which is what AI can easily and cheaply replace

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's Global Capability Centres (GCCs) are not just low-cost support in a new form, but are areas where cutting edge work is taking place, Chief Economic Adviser (CEA) V. Anantha Nageswaran said on Thursday. As such, these GCC jobs are also at a relatively lower risk of being replaced by Artificial Intelligence (AI), he added. However, the CEA did warn against the dangers of complacency, saying that other countries are already copying India's model. "It is cutting edge and increasingly so," Mr. Nageswaran said while speaking at a session during the Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) GCC Business Summit. "Global banks run their risk systems and trading platforms in Mumbai and Bangalore and elsewhere as well, car makers design their vehicles' embedded systems from Chennai and Pune, semiconductor firms carry out chip design, pharmaceutical companies run clinical analytics here, and consumer firms build and own entire digital products here in India," he added. Mr. Nageswaran said that the intellectual property created in these centers is real, with the patents being filed here, the products shipped from India and global roles increasingly held by people



CEA V. Anantha Nageswaran speaks at the inaugural session of the CII GCC Business Summit 2026 on Thursday. BY ARRANGEMENT

sitting in India. The CEA also sought to answer whether these GCCs would be under threat from the rise of AI and would these GCC jobs be automated soon. "Part of the model is indeed exposed," Mr. Nageswaran conceded. "The work that was routine, repetitive and rule bound is exactly the work that AI does most easily and most cheaply as well. If a centre's value rests only on doing simple tasks at low cost, then the value is under real threat. We should not pretend otherwise." However, he also said that this is not where most Indian centres are today, and that this was not the direction in which they are headed. "Artificial intelligence does not build, deploy or govern itself," Mr. Nageswaran explained. "Someone has to design these systems, train them, test them, correct them and

hold them to account. Someone has to decide where they should be used and where they must not be used." "Someone has to carry the responsibility when they fail," he added. "And that work is expanding and not shrinking. And a large and growing share of this kind of work is being done in India." Complacency matters The CEA, however, cautioned against complacency, saying that standing still meant allowing others to catch up. "Other countries are watching us and copying us," he asserted. "Our costs are rising. In some skills, our talent is already scarce, so indispensability is not a title that India can hold on to forever." He added that the move from cost centres to capability centres, and from execution to innovation has to be made by firms and by people, with the govern-

'India aims to be strategic leader in hosting GCCs'

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday said India aspires to become a "strategic leader" in hosting global capability centres (GCCs) of MNCs and become indispensable to the world's knowledge economy. India possesses "every ingredient" required to lead this transformation, she said. PTI

ment acting as a support. "Skilling is the clearest case," Mr. Nageswaran said. "We produce a very large number of graduates each year. We do not yet produce enough of those who are ready on day one. By some estimates, fewer than half of them are ready for the job on the day they arrive." "Closing that gap means universities, industry and the government working together, not one after the other, but at the same time," he said. He further said that the position India currently holds in the global capability centre market was one that it has to keep earning, over and over. "The moment we believe we have arrived is the moment others begin to catch up," he said. "So let us not celebrate too early. Let us treat this success not as a finishing line, but as a foundation or a milestone."

TCS Q1 net rises 4.6% to ₹14,349 crore, board okays interim dividend of ₹12 per share

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Consultancy Services Ltd. (TCS) reported a 4.6% growth in consolidated net profit for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026 to ₹13,349 crore as compared with ₹12,760 crore in the year-earlier period.

Consolidated revenue grew 14% YoY to ₹72,275 crore. Annualised AI revenue grew 13.6% quarter on quarter to \$2.6 billion in Q1 FY27. Operating margin was at 24%, while net margin stood at 19.2%. During the first quarter, the company had a Total Contract Value (TCV) of \$9.5 billion. Workforce strength at the end of the quarter was 5,93,798 as compared with 6,13,069 in the same period last year. Last Twelve Months (LTM) attrition (IT Services) was 13.6%, the company said in a filing. During the quarter, the company had added 9,279 employees. The board has approved an interim dividend of ₹12 per share. Record date is July 15, 2026 and the payment date is July 31, 2026. "Q1 FY27 reflects continued growth momentum and the strength of our strategic positioning, despite geopolitical and macro-economic headwinds. We delivered a strong order book of \$9.5 billion, including a marquee AI-led transformation deal with SKF, while continuing to add clients across key revenue bands and scaling our



Workforce strength at the end of the quarter was 5,93,798

AI business to a \$2.6 billion annualised revenue run rate," said Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director K. Krithivasan. "Q1 was characterised by strong growth across several services. We won multiple AI-led transformation deals with our dual commitment to AI-led optimisation as well as innovation-led outcomes," said Aarthi Subramanian, Executive Director, President and COO. Samir Seksaria, Chief Financial Officer, said, "In Q1, we rolled out annual wage hikes, strengthened our partnership ecosystem, and targeted investments to enhance long-term competitiveness." Commenting on the results Shubham Rathore, Principal Analyst, Gartner said, "TCS's resilient first-quarter performance, featuring an 8.5% year-over-year growth in net income to ₹13,849 crore, showcases the firm's capacity to maintain profitability through disciplined execution."

British insurer Aviva to get full ownership of Life JV in India

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Aviva is on course to becoming the first foreign insurer to hold 100% stake in an insurance joint venture in India with the British insurer announcing plans to acquire the remaining 26% stake in Aviva Life Insurance Company India from its joint venture partner. It has signed an agreement to purchase the 26% in Aviva India from its local joint venture partner Dabur Invest Corp. This will take Aviva's ownership of Aviva India to 100% and will give Aviva full control over the strategic direction of the business, the insurer



India now allows 100% FDI in insurance.

said on Thursday. The decision comes in the backdrop of India notifying the government's decision to permit 100% foreign direct investment (FDI) in insurance from the earlier limit of 74%.

SBI AMC is as competitive as any private firm: Singh

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Asset manager SBI Funds Management wants to differentiate itself from other PSUs as it was as aggressive and competitive as private sector firms, said joint CEO D.P. Singh. He was briefing the media on the ₹11,675 crore initial public offering (IPO) which is fully offer for sale. The price band is fixed at ₹545 to ₹547/share. Promoters SBI and Amundi India Holding will sell 10% stake. The quarterly average mutual fund assets under management is about ₹1,251 lakh crore.

**TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI**

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER

TENDER NOTICE

ADV No.17/03/CE/TTD/2026-27 & NIT No.27/SE-I/TTD/ 2026-27

Dt:07-07-2026

Name of work:1) Construction of S.V. Temple and Prakaram with 3 storied Rajagopuram at S.V. Diyakshetram at Parvathipuram, Parvathipuram Manyam District, Andhra Pradesh. **Amount:₹40.00 Lakhs; Time for Completion:18months.**

NOTE: For full details, log on to the Website <https://www.tirumala.org>.

TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.107) Date:09-07-2026

EXECUTIVE OFFICER

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY

RE - E-TENDER NOTICE

Re-Tender No. 04/2026-27/SE/PPD/KCH

AMRUT-2.0-Kochi Corporation-Providing underground sewerage networks and allied works in the erstwhile Division 54 of Kochi Corporation for the newly proposed SMLD STP at Elankulam

Cost of tender form : Rs. 21,052/- (inclusive of GST)

EMD : Rs. 500,000/-

Date and time of Opening Tender : 04/08/2026 3.30 pm

Last date of receipt of tender : 03/08/2026 3.00 pm

Phone : 8547638502 E-mail: seppdregionkochi@gmail.com

**The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd**

(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking),Sankarungulam,Kollam 691583

Phone : 0476-2612115 to 217, E-Mail : mkml@kmml.com

TENDER NOTICE

For more details please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmml.com

Sl No	Tender Id	Items
1	2026_KMML_859547_1	1) Fabrication & supply of Condensing Column cooler
2	2026_KMML_859525_1	1) Supply, Erection and Commissioning of Vertical Steam Turbine
3	2026_KMML_859767_1	1) Supply of Computer server
4	2026_KMML_859705_1	1) Global Tender for the Supply of High Purity Magnesium Metal

Chavara 09.07.2026

Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

**TAMIL NADU NEWSPRINT AND PAPERS LIMITED**

Unit-1, Kagithapuram - 639 136, Karur District, Tamil Nadu

Unit-2, Mondipatti - 621 306, Trichy District, Tamil Nadu

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Tender No.	Description	Due Date
262713 002358	Procurement of Segmented Bow Spreader Roll Assembly for Winder # 3 at TNPL Unit-I.	24.07.2026
262723 001443	Procurement of CATIONIC ROSIN for Board Machine (CCK) of TNPL Unit-II.	24.07.2026

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC Portal only.

Detailed Terms & Conditions are available in tender document at our websites: www.tnpl.com, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgep/app

DIPR/ 2246 /TENDER/2026

**भारतीय वानिकी अनुसंधान एवं शिक्षा परिषद**

INDIAN COUNCIL OF FORESTRY RESEARCH AND EDUCATION

(एनएफआरए, वन एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार का एक स्वायत्त निकाय)

(An Autonomous Body of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Govt. of India)

प०ओ० न्यू फॉरेस्ट, देहरादून – 248006 (उत्तराखण्ड)

P.O. New Forest, Dehra Dun – 248006 (Uttarakhand)

विज्ञापित संख्या 03/निदेशक, व०००अनु०००, जोरहाट, असम/2026-भा०वा०अ०शि०००

Advt. No. 03/Director, RFRI, Jorhat, Assam/2026-ICFRE

भारतीय वानिकी अनुसंधान एवं शिक्षा परिषद देहरादून के अन्तर्गत 7^{वें} वेंतन आयोग के वेलन स्तर 15 के वेलनमान में निदेशक, वर्षा वन अनुसंधान संस्थान, जोरहाट, असम का पद प्रतिनियुक्ति के आधार पर भरने हेतु आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं।

Applications are invited for filling up the post of Director, Rain Forest Research Institute, Jorhat, Assam in the pay scale at Level-15 of 7th CPC Pay Matrix on deputation basis at Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education, Dehradun

उपरोक्त पद हेतु इच्छुक अभ्यर्थी भा०वा०अ०शि००० की वेबसाइट <http://www.icfre.org> में दिने गये विस्तृत विज्ञापन के अनुसार आवेदन कर सकते हैं। आवेदन प्राप्त करने की अन्तिम तिथि 24.08.2026 है।

The interested candidates may apply for the above said post as per detailed advertisement available at ICFRE website <http://www.icfre.org>. The last date of receipt of applications is 24.08.2026

सचिव, भा०वा०अ०शि०००
Secretary, ICFRE

**Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Ltd.**

Gandhi Block, Swasthya Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur-302005 (Raj.)

Phone No: 0141-2228066, 2228064, Website: <http://rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in>

E-mail: edpsrmsc@rajasthan.gov.in

Ref. No. :- F.02 (445)/RMSC/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-07/2026-27/4606 Dated :- 06/07/2026

Corrigendum - II in NIB - 07/2026-27

In Reference to NIB No. F.02 (445)/RMSC/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-07/2026-27/4384 Dated :- 02.06.2026 UBN No. MSC2627GLRC00025

Corrigendum-II is issued for date extension in bid. All details may be seen on <https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> & <https://www.rmsh.health.rajasthan.gov.in>.

Director (Proc.)
Raj.Samwadi/C/26/6457

RMSCL

**VISAKHAPATNAM PORT AUTHORITY**

VISAKHAPATNAM

E-Tender Call Notice: 2026_VPT_281806_1, Dt. 23.06.2026.

On behalf of the Members of Board of VPA, E-Tender is invited in Single Stage two steps system from the experienced bidders meeting the pre-qualifying criteria for the work mentioned below through online bidding on the Website <http://www.etenders.gov.in>

SUB: UP GRADATION OF THE EXISTING 80 BEDDED GOLDEN JUBILEE HOSPITAL TO A 300 BEDDED MULTI-DISCIPLINARY SUPER SPECIALITY HOSPITAL AT VISAKHAPATNAM PORT ON DESIGN, BUILD, FINANCE, OPERATE AND TRANSFER (DBFOT) BASIS" – Due Date of Opening :06.08.2026

SECRETARY

**RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LTD.**

CHINABRA THERMAL POWER STATION, CHINABRA

E-TENDER NOTICE No. 4109 (RVU2627GLOB00737)

Online tenders are invited for "Supply of spares for BOMABA Make LPBP Stop and Control Valves". Tender details are available on websites <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> (for e-tender), www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/rvunl & www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in.

Raj.Samwadi/C/26/6570

RVUN/PR-4424

Addl. Chief Engineer (O&M)

**Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Ltd.**

Gandhi Block, Swasthya Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur-302005 (Raj.)

Phone No: 0141-2228066, 2228064, Website: <http://rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in>

E-mail: edpsrmsc@rajasthan.gov.in

Ref. No. :- F.02 (441)/RMSC/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-03/2026-27/309829 Dated :- 30/06/2026

Corrigendum - I in NIB - 03/2026-27

In Reference to NIB No. F.02 (441)/RMSC/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-03/2026-27/4494 Dated :- 24.06.2026 UBN No. MSC2627GLRC00028

Corrigendum-I is issued for date extension in bid. All details may be seen on <https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> & <https://www.rmsh.health.rajasthan.gov.in>.

Director (Proc.)
Raj.Samwadi/C/26/6458

RMSCL

**JAIPUR VIDYUT VITRAN NIGAM LIMITED**

Regd.Office:- Jan Path, Vidyut Bhawan, Jyoti Nagar,Jaipur

Office of the Superintending Engineer (PM Surya Ghar)

Old Power House Premises, Near Ram Mandir, Bani Park, Jaipur

Email: sepsmsuryaghar@jvnl.org / sepsmgby@gmail.com

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-bids in two parts (Techno-commercial bid and Price bid) are invited from eligible bidders for the work for Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning Of 1,00,000 Nos. Of Consumers Through Net Metering And O&M For 5 Years With Additional 5 Years By Competitive Bidding For Grid Connected Rooftop Solar Plants Through Utility Led Aggregation (Capex) Mode In Jaipur Discom Under Pm-Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana Participating bidders can download complete set of bidding documents from e-procurement portal <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> from 08.07.2026 onwards. Last Date/Time for receipt of online bids through e-procurement portal is 29.07.2026 upto 05.00 PM.For further details regarding Works, Tender Notifications & Specifications please visit website <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> & <http://www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/jvnl> UBN:VVN2627WLB000213

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (PM SURYA GHAR)

Raj.Samwadi/C/26/6538

JPR-3186 (2026)

For Electricity Complaints Toll Free No. 1800 180 6507

WASHINGTON

Trump says 11 jets downed during India-Pakistan hostilities last year



U.S. President Donald Trump has repeated his claim of settling the conflict between India and Pakistan, adding that 11 jets were shot down during the four-day hostilities in May last year. India has consistently denied any third-party intervention. India launched Operation Sindoor in response to the Pahalgam terror attack. PTI

DHAKA

Landslide kills 7 children, teacher at Rohingya camp in Bangladesh



At least seven children and a teacher were killed in a landslide caused by monsoon rains at a Rohingya refugee camp in Bangladesh's southeastern Cox's Bazar. Four of the children were killed at the scene of the landslide, while others died at the local hospital after they were rescued, officials said. PTI

LONDON

Total Eclipse singer Bonnie Tyler, queen of the 80s power ballad, dies



Welsh singer Bonnie Tyler, best known for her powerful, haunting love song *Total Eclipse of the Heart*, has died aged 75 in hospital in Portugal, her family announced on Thursday. With her distinctive husky voice, tousled mane of blonde hair and black eyeliner, Tyler was instantly recognisable as the queen of 1980s power ballad. AFP

SAN FRANCISCO

OpenAI launches ChatGPT Work, delving into workplace automation



OpenAI on Thursday unveiled ChatGPT Work, an agent in its popular chatbot designed to execute tasks across different applications and files, marking the startup's latest push into workplace automation. The launch reflects intensifying competition to build and sell AI tools for professional use. REUTERS

U.S., Iran exchange more attacks across West Asia, threatening deal

Iran reports U.S. strikes around the perimeter of Bushehr nuclear plant as U.S. officials say they hit about 90 Iranian military targets; new fighting erupted hours before the burial of Khamenei; Tehran officials report that U.S. attacks killed 17 people

Agence France-Presse
MASHHAD

New fighting erupted between the United States and Iran hours ahead of the burial of long-time Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei on Thursday, with Tehran targeting U.S. allies in the region and American strikes hitting the perimeter of an Iranian nuclear power plant.

The renewed hostilities, triggered by tensions over the Strait of Hormuz, sparked concerns of a return to full-scale war after an April ceasefire and a June U.S.-Iran accord ended five weeks of conflict.



Mourners carry a banner against Donald Trump as they gather on the day of Khamenei's burial in Mashhad on Thursday. REUTERS

This was the second day in a row that the decades-old foes exchanged attacks, with Iranian officials reporting the U.S. attacks had killed 17 people.

— where the military said it had intercepted eight missiles launched from Iran.

The fighting came with Iran preparing to bury Khamenei, who was killed alongside close family members on the first day of the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran on February 28, in his hometown of Mashhad.

‘Effort to overshadow’

The United States targeted the perimeter of Iran's only civilian nuclear plant with a strike on Thursday, Iranian state media reported, citing the deputy governor of Bushehr province.

The Iranian Foreign Ministry said the U.S. attacks

targeted civilian infrastructure, including railway bridges, and described the strikes as a “gross war crime”.

U.S. military officials said Thursday's strikes hit approximately 90 Iranian military targets, including air defence systems, missile and drone storage sites.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards accused the United States of an “effort to overshadow” Khamenei's funeral with its attacks.

In a sign of the security tensions, at least one fighter jet escorted the plane carrying Khamenei's coffin to its final burial in Mashhad.

Ukrainian drones hit more Russian oil facilities and set two oil tankers ablaze in the Sea of Azov on Thursday, a day after U.S. President Donald Trump pledged to grant Kyiv a licence to manufacture the Patriot air defence systems to protect its cities.

A top Ukrainian official, meanwhile, cautioned that it could take a year or more for the country to produce Patriot interceptor missiles.

A Ukrainian drone strike triggered a fire at an oil depot in the western Russian city of Tver, according to acting Governor Vitaly Korolyov.

Oil reservoirs also were set ablaze by drones in Vyazniki, in the southern



People queue to refuel their cars at a petrol station in Moscow as Ukrainian strikes on its facilities crimp domestic supply. AFP

Stavropol region, said Governor Vladimir Vladimirov, forcing the evacuation of several apartment buildings near the facility.

In the Sea of Azov, Ukrainian drones set two oil tankers on fire, according to Rostov Governor Yuri Slusar, who said one of the ships was still burning and its crew evacuated.

The attack was the latest in a series of strikes on oil tankers in the area in recent days, part of Ukraine efforts to cut fuel supplies to the Crimean Peninsula, which Russia illegally annexed in 2014.

Russia's Defence Ministry said its defences downed 73 Ukrainian drones during the past day.

Ebola death toll in Congo reaches 600, as new cases surge

Associated Press
KINSHASA

New suspected cases of Ebola have been reported in parts of Congo that were previously unaffected, the government said on Thursday, as the death toll in the country's latest Ebola outbreak reached 600.

According to the Congolese Health Ministry, suspected cases have now been recorded in the provinces of Tshopo and Haut-Uele, signalling the continued spread of the disease beyond the epicentre in Ituri.

A Congolese government report, published late Wednesday, said two new cases were suspected

in Kisangani, in Tshopo province. The Minister did not say how many cases were suspected in Haut-Uele. The total number of confirmed cases across the country has now reached 1,759.

According to the report, one of the two suspected cases in Tshopo was linked to the Nia-Nia health zone in Ituri province, where the first cases were reported, while the other case “has no apparent geographical connection to known outbreaks.”

Last week, clinical trials for treatment began after researchers launched a highly anticipated study in the hope of fighting the deadly virus.

Civic protest



Protesters chant slogans during a demonstration by the 'March and March' movement, calling upon the government to enforce tougher measures against illegal immigration and to deport undocumented foreign nationals, in Mtwalume, South Africa on Thursday. AFP

Syria welcomes U.S. announcement of removal from blacklist

Agence France-Presse
DAMASCUS

Damascus welcomed a U.S. announcement that it would remove Syria from its list of “state sponsors of terrorism”, a move that one economist said opened the door to economic recovery and foreign investment.

“A dark page in Syria's history has been turned,” Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shaibani wrote on X.

The United States announced on Wednesday that it would remove Syria from its blacklist of countries it accuses of supporting terrorism, a designation it placed on Syria nearly five decades ago



Asaad al-Shaibani and which had curbed investment in the country.

The Syrian Foreign Ministry called the move “an important development in the course of Syrian-American relations”.

The move will be effective in 45 days unless lawmakers take the unlikely step of blocking it.

Shoe factory fire kills at least 28 people in southeast China

Reuters
BEIJING

At least 28 people were killed in a fire at a shoe factory in southeastern China on Thursday, state-run Xinhua news agency reported, after flames engulfed the multi-storey building, trapping workers on the rooftop.

The fire broke out at around noon local time in the city of Jinjiang in Fujian province at footwear manufacturer Huiteng.

A total of 239 people were at the factory when the fire broke out, Xinhua said. It said 213 were evacuated, two of whom died after being taken to hospital for treatment. Another 26 people previously re-



Firefighters at the scene of a footwear factory fire in Jiangtou village in southeastern China's Fujian province on Thursday. AP

ported missing at the scene were confirmed dead.

Jinjiang, in the coastal Fujian province, is a major footwear and clothing manufacturing hub and is often referred to as China's “shoe capital”.

Preliminary findings indicate the fire started on the ground floor of the fac-

tory, a local official told CCTV. Shoe-making materials stored in the building were highly flammable and could cause a blaze to spread rapidly, the official said.

People in charge of the company and “other relevant personnel” have been taken into custody.

Sri Lankan universities close and shift to online classes as dengue cases top 65,000 in the island

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka's University of Colombo has decided to move some lectures online amid the persisting dengue surge on the island, authorities said. The decision comes after the University of Moratuwa and the University of the Visual and Performing Arts temporarily closed their campuses, as the country confronts one of its worst outbreaks of the vector-borne disease.

The National Dengue Control Unit has reported a total of 65,034 dengue cases this year, with capital Colombo accounting for about a fifth of the cases. As many as 45 dengue-re-



Prevention push: A municipal worker fumigates a residential area during a dengue prevention campaign in Colombo. AFP

lated deaths have been recorded as of Wednesday.

Since May this year, the University of Colombo has recorded a total of 71 cases, cumulatively, among its students, according to Vice Chancellor Professor Indika Mahesh Karunathilake.

“The Faculty of Arts saw more cases of fever, some of which could even be viral or chikungunya. The students were concerned, so we decided to shift to online lessons. The decision is not entirely to do with the current spread,

As many as 45 dengue-related deaths have been recorded in country

but it is to allow students to rest and recover. We are giving other faculties the option of hybrid lessons,” he told *The Hindu*.

As the number of dengue cases across the island rose last month, authorities appointed a military-led team to monitor the outbreak, while hospitals reported overcrowding of patients. “The tri-forces and police have helped us intensify inspection, including through drone cameras, clean up campaigns, fogging operations

and awareness,” a senior official with the Unit told *The Hindu*. “We need to wait for about two weeks, considering the incubation period and life cycle of the vectors for a realistic assessment. While we are doing our best, the situation is still challenging,” the official said, comparing the current outbreak to the one seen in 2017, Sri Lanka's largest. That year, a total of 1,86,101 cases were reported.

Public health officials have linked the current outbreak to the debris from Cyclone Ditwah, which hit Sri Lanka in December 2025, claiming over 600 lives and leaving behind a long path of destruction.

BACKING HIS MEN

We are not influenced by anyone, says FIFA refereeing chief Collina



REUTERS

The FIFA chief refereeing officer Pierluigi Collina has strongly dismissed allegations of external influence on officiating. “With a high number of matches played in a short period, it is normal that some things do not go as expected. Unfounded allegations have no place. Nobody can question the integrity of the match officials”.

NEW DAWN

Jorge Jesus to take over as the Portugal coach after its WC exit



REUTERS

Jorge Jesus is set to be appointed Portugal coach after Roberto Martinez stepped down in the wake of its World Cup exit, according to sources. The 71-year-old Portuguese will replace Spaniard Martinez, who left the job after Cristiano Ronaldo's side slumped to a 0-1 last-16 defeat to Spain.

BANTER

I expect you to go out on a rowing trip: Haaland on Rooney's promise



REUTERS

Norway striker Erling Haaland playfully reminded Wayne Rooney to honour his promise after the former England captain had joked that he would row down the River Mersey if Norway eliminated Brazil from the World Cup. “Rooney, I expect you to go out on a rowing trip,” Haaland said with a grin on his latest vlog on YouTube.

ROAD TO RECOVERY

Henderson undergoes surgery after suffering freak arm injury



AP

England midfielder Jordan Henderson has undergone surgery on his broken arm after a freak injury he suffered following the team's World Cup last-16 win over Mexico. Henderson was taken to hospital after having left the field on a stretcher. “Surgery done. Let's get ready for the big one on Saturday,” he wrote on social media.



No way past: Spain is yet to concede a goal. AFP

Will Belgium find chinks in Spain's ironclad defence?

Agence France-Presse
LOS ANGELES

Belgium will meet Spain in the World Cup quarterfinals on Friday with the daunting task of breaching the European champion's watertight defence for the first time at the tournament.

By beating Cristiano Ronaldo's Portugal 1-0 on Monday, Luis de la Fuente's side became the first team in history to record six consecutive World Cup clean sheets.

Spain has not shown the attacking flair of France but it is playing the careful, possession-based football that took it to glory in South Africa in 2010. The prodigiously gifted Lamine Yamal is the team's most potent attacker on paper, but the teenager arrived while still recovering from a late-season injury and has netted just once in five games. But the brutal truth is that Spain does not need

Saturday's match

QUARTERFINAL



Spain vs. Belgium

00.30 A.M.

THE DAY AND TIME PERTAIN TO INDIA

to score many goals to win – it has conceded just six shots on target in its five matches so far.

Belgium, captained by the impressive Youri Tielemans, has had a rollercoaster ride in the knockout phase thus far.

The ongoing World Cup is likely the last hurrah for the remainder of the nation's so-called ‘Golden Generation’, including creative midfielder Kevin De Bruyne, striker Romelu Lukaku and goalkeeper Thibaut Courtois.

While they have not been at their best, they remain match-winners.

FIFA WORLD CUP

Ayon Sengupta
BOSTON

There is a particular kind of grief in sport that has little to do with defeat. It arrives not when a team loses, but when time finally catches up with the players who once seemed beyond its reach.

This World Cup has felt full of those moments. Luka Modric leaving with Croatia gone. Cristiano Ronaldo, who for so long bent matches to his will, walking away from another one. Manuel Neuer, for years football's last great illusionist in goal, no longer carrying the same aura of permanence.

These were not just elite footballers; they were part of the architecture of the sport.

Every major tournament had them somewhere in the frame. Modric gliding through the midfield with that strange combination of delicacy and defiance, Ronaldo summoning goals and drama with the force of habit, Neuer redrawing what a sweeper-goalkeeper could be.

Their brilliance



Fading away: Veterans Modric, Ronaldo and Neuer did not have the happy ending they would have hoped for at the start of the tournament. AFP & GETTY IMAGES



stretched across so many summers that it began to feel normal. But sport, with its occasional cruelty, has a way of reminding us that permanence was never part of the bargain. This World Cup has exposed the mortality of men who once seemed immune to it.

The legs do not always obey. The recovery takes a little longer. The moments still come, but not always on command. The body, eventually, begins to negotiate with the mind. And so, one by one, the stars who seemed to live outside

time have begun to look mere mortals.

Perhaps that is why Lionel Messi's presence feels so affecting. He is still here, still resisting and still playing as if he has found a private loophole in the laws of ageing.

Around him, Argentina carries the urgency of men who know exactly what this moment means.

It recalls, in its own way, those late-career years of Sachin Tendulkar, when Indian cricket seemed to understand that every innings, every tour, every

knock might be one of the last chances to honour a figure who had towered over its imagination for a generation.

Then came Roger Federer, making tennis look too graceful to be real; Rafael Nadal with his fury, faith and wounded endurance; Novak Djokovic, the last great disruptor who has also now reached the stage where each tournament is shadowed by the thought of how many more are left.

And now football's old Gods, too, are being claimed by time.

Muchova, Noskova set up all-Czechia finale

N. Sudarshan
LONDON

If you are an on-court artist in tennis, Wimbledon is your greatest canvas.

On Thursday, Karolina Muchova painted her best portrait yet by beating seventh seed Coco Gauff 6-2, 1-6, 7-6 [12-10] and entering her maiden singles final at the All England Club.

A first appearance in the summit clash is coming rather late for the 29-year-old from Czechia. A French Open finalist in 2023, a two-time US Open (2023 and 2024) and a one-time Australian Open (2021) semifinalist, Wimbledon was an anomaly.

In fact, she had exited in the first round in each of the last four editions. But that dismal record now stands emphatically corrected, as the tenth seed battled past a spirited Gauff, even saving a match-point in the nerve-wracking deciding set tie-break.

On Saturday, Muchova will take on compatriot Linda Noskova, who overcame Ukraine's Marta Kostyuk 6-4, 6-4. It will be a first women's singles final at SW19 between compatriots since Serena Williams met sister Venus in 2009.



Dream run: Muchova prevailed in a high-quality contest to reach her maiden Wimbledon final. AFP

Muchova played a relatively clean first set, with her stylish and soothing tennis the ideal balm to many a burning eye in the furnace-like Centre Court.

For the second stanza, Gauff brought her own exotic brush and started painting a picture which was aesthetically a notch lower but first-rate nonetheless.

Third set was where their top levels matched. The quality amplified, like it happens with two pairing frequencies at reso-

nance. At 4-4, Muchova erased two break-point opportunities. At 5-5, she went 0-30 down, but wriggled out by executing an advancing forehand, an inside-out winner and another unreturnable from the backhand wing.

Gauff was largely clinical on her serve and exhibited incisive fore-court play as the contest slipped into an inevitable super tie-break.

Once there, Muchova went 6-3 up by combining a dipping pass, low volley,

service-winner down the ‘T’, Boris Becker-style diving drop-volley and an ace. Gauff clawed her way back to 6-6, with her response highlighted by two excellent forehand winners.

At 8-8, Muchova was put off by a time-violation warning for a late serve and ended up committing an unforced error.

On the ensuing match-point, Gauff drilled a powerful serve that Muchova could only block, but instead of slapping the ball

away, the American attempted an indecisive drop and dumped it into the net.

A beautiful lob earned Muchova her first match-point but Gauff snatched it away with a looping cross-court pass. The Czech, who seemed slightly bothered by hip issue, regained her focus and unleashed a superb forehand winner. A contest-ending two-fisted backhand soon followed.

In boys' singles, India's Arnav Vijay Paparkar lost to United States' Jordan Lee 2-6, 5-7 in the quarterfinals. But the 18-year-old, for whom this is the first year at Slams and also the last year in juniors, was overall satisfied.

“I am happy with the experience,” he told *The Hindu*. “I lost in the first round in Australia, then made the third round at French [Open] and now the quarters here.

“I will soon be full time on the professional circuit and I hope to get into the top-1000 in six months,” added the Pune lad, who is currently ranked No. 1645.

Other result:
Girls' doubles (quarterfinal): Victoria Barros & Nauhany Leme Da Silva (Bra) bt Maaya Rajeshwaran & Thea Frodin (USA) 3-6, 6-4, [10-6].

Brook and Salt on song as England seals series win

Press Trust of India
BRISTOL

India's winless run was extended to six matches on Thursday after England skipper Harry Brook and Phil Salt powered the host to a nine-wicket win in the fourth T20I here. The victory, which was achieved with 37 balls to spare, helped England take an unassailable 3-0 lead in the five-match series.

Chasing a modest 159, England suffered an early jolt when left-arm pacer Arshdeep Singh dismissed Jos Buttler in the third over. But, Brook (79 n.o., 35b, 8x4, 4x6) and Salt (59 n.o., 42b, 9x4, 1x6) sent the Indian bowlers on a leather hunt during their unbroken second-wicket partnership of 146 off 70 balls.

Earlier, Shreyas appeared to be batting on a different surface as he came up with a superb knock (80 not out, 49b, 4x4, 5x6) to steer his side to 158 for seven.

Shreyas, who struck five sixes and four boundaries, held the innings together even as wickets tumbled around him. The other Indian batters paid the price



All guns blazing: Salt and Brook sent the Indian bowlers on a leather hunt during their match-winning partnership. REUTERS

for being too aggressive on a bouncy wicket.

The captain added 53 with Shivam Dube (22), but with wickets falling regularly, Shreyas was forced to assume the role of sheet-anchor. He cut loose in the 18th over, smashing leg-spinner Adil Rashid for two sixes and a four as 20 came off it. That over, however, proved to be an exception as the England bowlers executed their plans superbly.

Sam Curran conceded just four in the penultimate over while Jofra Archer (two for 20) finished the in-

nings with a tight final over in which two wickets fell, including the run out of Axar Patel.

The extra bounce again took a toll on the Indian top-order as Archer removed Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (15) for the second time in as many innings before new-ball partner Josh Tongue (two for 36) dismissed Ishan Kishan (4) within the PowerPlay.

The scores: India 158/7 in 20 overs (Shreyas 80 n.o., Archer 2/20, Tongue 2/36) lost to England 159/1 in 13.5 overs (Salt 59 n.o., Brook 79 n.o.). **Toss:** India.



The midfielder has been as instrumental as Haaland in Norway's run to its maiden quarterfinal; next up for him is a tough test against England

Captain Martin Odegaard has been just as instrumental to Norway's first-ever quarterfinal qualification. The midfielder provided an assist in each of his first three WC appearances – against Iraq, Senegal, and Ivory Coast. He became only the third

Operating as the play-maker in Stale Solbakken's 4-3-3 set-up, the Arsenal man has become the hub

It's a role that rarely produces the eye-catching numbers which strikers get credit for. Still, the underlying data tells its own story: only a few midfielders at this World Cup have combined creative output with defensive work rate as consistently as Norway's 'leader'. As Norway prepares to face England, Odegaard's ability to dictate the flow may decide how far Norway's 'golden generation' can go.

The scores: Chennai Boys HSS Nungambakkam 64 in 22.2 overs (S. Abishek Ram 3/6) lost to St. Bedes' A/ 67/1 in 7.4 overs (V. Samjeevaava 31 n.o.).

APL Global School 152/9 in 30 overs (R. Shravan 53, N. Neil Nithwin 39, N. Sonitray/ 5/15) lost to Olive Tree Global School 154/0 in 19 overs (B. Siddhartha 68 n.o., J. Ethnan Paul 62 n.o.).

SBOA School & Jr College 93 in 28.1 overs (S. Rahul Pala 4/23, E.J. Kavin 3/7) lost to Ramachandra PS 94/2 in 13.1 overs (V. Rithaesh 58 n.o.).

Santhome-A 208/7 in 30 overs (M. Shyam 50, S. Rithvik 38, B. Kundan Kumar 36, Vyshnav 3/40) bt PSBB 'B' 82/4 in 20.2 overs (S. Arjun 30). **Note:** Target revised to 152 runs in 20.2 overs & Santhome won by 70 runs.

St. Bede's B 236/3 in 30 overs (A. Designar 87, M.K. Raghav 39 n.o.) bt The Schram Academy CBSE 60 in 26.1 overs (S. Prajan 3/5).

Nellai Nadar MHSS 98 in 29.3 overs (S. Sabareesh 3/14, S.S. Sarabesh Siva 4/27) lost to St. Michaels Academy 100/6 in 27.5 overs.

Saraswathi Vidyalaya 70 in 26.5 overs (R.S. Sujithan 3/6, P. Mithun Karthick 3/12) lost to Ebenezer MHSS-A 71/1 in 11 overs (P.B. Shourya Kumar 39 n.o.).

Don Bosco-B 193/7 in 30 overs (S. Mayank Dhruva 47, S. Saif Ali 40, S. Sanjay 34 n.o.) bt Maharishi Vidya Mandir 68 in 22.3 overs (N. Haethish 5/8).

The Hindu Senior-A 38 in 15.2 overs (S. Aniruth 5/18, N. Rahul 3/12) lost to Heartfulness Intl. School NIOS-A 40/0 in 4 overs.

Sishya OMR School 192/8 in 30 overs (S. Advaito 80, Joel Koshy Mathews 49, H. Gurusaran 3/28) bt Jawahar Vidyalaya-B 137 in 26.1 overs (M. Mohamed Farhan 38, S. Sachin 3/19).

Jawahar Vidyalaya-A 127 in 30



IDTT - IDream Tiruppur Tamizhans; **DD** - Dindigul Dragons; **TGC** - Trichy Grand Cholas; **MP** - Madurai Panthers; **CSG** - Chepauk Super Gillies; **NRK** - Nellai Royal Kings; **KK** - Kovai Kings; **SSS** - SKM Salem Spartans

Bholanath had not only misbehaved with her but also warned her to not step out of line or face consequences. Alleging that the trigger was her complaint against coach Sudhir Golla for sexually exploiting female players, Asunta detailed her experience.



Of all the failures that have liberally dotted the coach's brief tenure, the most chastening will be the 2-0 rout in Ireland, followed closely by 76 all out against England in Nottingham; Several of India's methods in the last couple of years have been steeped in madness that is all too visible

R. Kaushik

I t's been a while since India had a disastrous overseas cricketing sojourn. A long, long while, come to think of it.

There was a time even the most invested and committed supporter of the Indian team would take the worst for granted when their heroes embarked on an away Test tour, especially of Australia or England or New Zealand (from 2006, the voodoo of South Africa went away, though it is the only land where India haven't won a series yet). A draw was viewed as a moral victory, inasmuch as something like that exists, while a defeat of any kind was accepted philosophically and with equanimity.

All that has changed in the last decade or so. Adding belief and self-confidence to their kitbag to go with historically unquestioned immense skills, India have become a gathering force in overseas conditions too. They haven't lost a Test series in Sri Lanka since 2008, stacked up consecutive triumphs in Australia (2019 and 2021), held England to a creditable 2-2 draw last summer despite embracing the exciting and nervy phase of transition, and have tamed the West Indian lion in its own den every time since the three-match series in 2006 when they came away on the right side of a 1-0 score line.

Apart from establishing themselves as a formidable Test entity everywhere in the world, except perhaps in New Zealand where their only series victory in the last 55 or so years came in 2009, India are a gun white-ball force. They have been there and thereabouts in all significant competitions, are the simultaneous holders of the 50-over Champions Trophy and T29 World Cup crowns, and have lost a mere twice in the last four ICC limited-overs events between and including the 2023 50-over World Cup and the 2026 T20 World Cup.

The excellent run is testament to the strong systems in place in the country to identify and nurture talent. While India may not be as open as Pakistan in bleeding delicately young talent or as Sri Lanka in placing faith in the unorthodox, they are slowly shaking off the conventional straitjacket to which they often restricted themselves. That's why they didn't think twice about unleashing Jasprit Bumrah, the extraordinary bowler with the extraordinary release -- among other things -- more than a decade back, or the supremely gifted and precocious 15-year-old from Bihar's Samastipur, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, less than a week back.

Sooryavanshi's international debut was eagerly awaited from the time he proved in the summer during IPL 2026 that his exploits to that point weren't just a flash in the pan. A tournament-high 776 runs that earned him the Orange Cap ahead of such established names as Virat Kohli and current Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill, as well as last edition's leading run-getter B. Sai Sudharsan, meant his tender age could no longer work against him. Sooryavanshi didn't do a great deal in his first two T20Is in England, scoring 14 in his maiden appearance and backing it up with 13 in the second, but 24 of those runs have come through a brace of sixes in each of the two outings, most certainly the teasing appetiser before what ought to be a sumptuous main course.

The clamour for Sooryavanshi's inclusion had reached a crescendo immediately after Ajit Agarkar's selection panel picked him for the seven-match T20I odyssey in Ireland (two games) and England. Almost as if because they felt they had to keep the growing voices at bay, India delayed his introduction by three games. But once they were stunned by the Irish in both games and once Sanju Samson courted a third successive failure by following up scores of 5 and 0 against Ireland with 1 in the first T20I against the English in Chester-le-Street, the think-tank was almost compelled to unshackle the devastating left-handed opener.

That Sooryavanshi's induction came at the expense of Samson has divided opinion. The frustratingly inconsistent Samson - he averages 27.01 in 65 T20Is despite posting three centuries and six half-tons in 57 innings - appeared to have

turned the corner with a hat-trick of match-winning knocks at the business-end of the home T20 World Cup in February-March. The Player of the Tournament at the World Cup is still very much in the scheme of things; he figures in the Asian Games squad even though he has been left out of the team to play three matches in Zimbabwe later this month. But as India scrambled to accommodate Sooryavanshi, Samson it was who had to be sacrificed.

Head coach Gautam Gambhir, in the crosshairs after this latest UK misadventure, said at a press conference on Monday that he had had a conversation with the Kerala wicketkeeper-opener, insisting that Samson knew the score but adding that whatever was spoken would remain between the coach and the dropped player. Gambhir is fiercely passionate and an extremely proud professional, wonderful but hardly unexpected qualities; he might not believe so, but he is under pressure to deliver results after a mixed bag.

Depending on which side of the fence one is on, Gambhir is slightly in the red or moderately in the blue in his two years in charge of a successful, settled squad he inherited from Rahul Dravid in July 2024. His very first tour at the helm was a precursor of things to come. India swept the T20I series 3-0 in Sri Lanka, fashioning victories from impossible situations including in the Super Over in the final game in Pallekele. But they were also humbled 2-0 in the ODIs - the first ended in a tie and the umpires seemed to forget that the ICC mandated a Super Over to break the deadlock - as the first

indications that India's fallibility against spin would come back to haunt them lay exposed.

Subsequently, Gambhir has overseen stunning title runs in the Champions Trophy, the T20 Asia Cup and the T20 World Cup, but he has also presided over some of the darkest phases in Indian cricket. A singularly humiliating 46 all out against New Zealand in the Bengaluru Test in October 2024. A record 408-run hammering at the hands of South Africa in November last year. A 3-0 surrender to New Zealand in November 2024 followed by a 2-0 annihilation by South Africa 12 months later meant Gambhir's CV was already replete with diametrically opposite results. Now, India's longest winless streak in T20I history has added to the feisty former opener's discomfiture because while he might hold the view that results alone don't dictate progress, there is no other tangible, measurable yardstick, is there?

Will/should Gambhir count the Test retirements in that order, within five months of each other, of R. Ashwin, Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli between December 2024 and May 2025, as a success of sorts? The loss of this bulk of experience and quality inevitably plunged India to the throes of transition - at one stage, he didn't like that word, choosing instead to go with inexperience before transition returned to his lexicon after the Protean rout. With challenging away tours of Sri Lanka and New Zealand in wait ahead of the five-Test home showdown against Australia early next year, Gambhir will know in his heart of hearts that anything less than a third entry into the final of the World Test Championship in

four editions will be perceived as a huge comedown.

Of all the failures that have liberally dotted his brief tenure, the most chastening will be the 2-0 rout in Ireland, followed closely by 76 all out against England in Nottingham earlier this week, which consigned Shreyas Iyer's men to their heaviest defeat in 20-over internationals. Gambhir harped on the 'high risk, high reward' theme to almost wish away the disaster, falling back on the absence of key figures (Bumrah, Hardik Pandya) as an oblique excuse of sorts. Had he not been party to the dumping and omission from the squad of World Cup-winning skipper Suryakumar Yadav, he could have invoked that eventuality too, one suspects. The fact of the matter is that India have been slow to react and adapt, both against the spunky Irish and a fired-up England, themselves looking for minor crumbs of consolation after their outstanding chase of India's 253 in the semifinal of the World Cup ended just seven agonising runs short.

India have parted ways with coaches with much better results - Anil Kumble walked away in a huff in 2017, acknowledging that his partnership with skipper Kohli was no longer 'tenable' despite overseeing Test series wins in the Caribbean, and at home against England and Australia, as well as taking the team to the final of the Champions Trophy in England where we might have had a different tale to tell had Kohli adamantly not chosen to chase on a superb batting surface. If Gambhir seems immune to the slew of defeats that would almost certainly have consumed anyone else, it is because he knows that he continues to enjoy the confidence and the backing of those who make the influential calls in Indian cricket, whether they are a part of the Indian board or not.

Several of India's methods in the last couple of years have been steeped in madness that is all too visible, not least the ill-advised recall to the T20 setup as vice-captain, no less, of Gill and his subsequent omission with the World Cup imminent, all in the space of five months. Gambhir is open to accountability just as much as the next individual is, and it's time he helps the side turn the corner and stack up the consistency that has made India so feared across formats for so many years.

The predicament of the coach and their support group of any team at any level anywhere in the world is unenviable. For all the strategising and analysing and the backroom work that goes in before a match or a tournament, there is nothing they can do in realistic terms once the action begins beyond hoping that their charges remember the plans and are up to scratch when it comes to execution on a given day. But the buck will stop with the coach, of that there can be no arguments. Gambhir often speaks of wanting to fulfil the aspirations of India's 140 crore people. This would be as good a time as any to translate words into deeds.

THE GIST

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Apart from establishing themselves as a formidable Test entity everywhere in the world, except perhaps in New Zealand where their only series victory in the last 55 or so years came in 2009, India are a gun white-ball force

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The clamour for Sooryavanshi's inclusion had reached a crescendo immediately after Ajit Agarkar's selection panel picked him for the seven-match T20I odyssey in Ireland (two games) and England. Almost as if because they felt they had to keep the growing voices at bay, India delayed his introduction by three games

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Gambhir is fiercely passionate and an extremely proud professional, wonderful but hardly unexpected qualities; he might not believe so, but he is under pressure to deliver results after a mixed bag



Why more Indian couples are being diagnosed with secondary infertility

Analyses of India's National Family Health Survey data show secondary infertility rose from roughly 19.5% in the early 1990s to about 28.6% by 2015-2016 – close to a doubling in a single generation; there are multiple factors that are contributing to this including age-related issues and changes in the body between the first and the second child

Richika Sahay Shukla

A few weeks ago, a couple sat in my consulting room looking almost apologetic. They already had a bright six-year-old waiting at home. “We feel silly taking your time, doctor,” the mother said. “We have one child. Everyone keeps telling us to just be grateful.” And then, quietly, she started to cry.

I have heard that phrase – “at least you have one” – more times than I can count. It is almost always meant kindly. It almost always lands like a door being shut. And it is one of the reasons the couples I see struggling to conceive a second time carry their grief so silently.

Understanding the condition

The condition has a name: secondary infertility – the difficulty conceiving or carrying a pregnancy after you have already had a baby. For years it was brushed aside as a non-problem. The numbers say otherwise.

Analyses of India's National Family Health Survey data show secondary infertility rose from roughly 19.5% in the early 1990s to about 28.6% by 2015-2016 – close to a doubling in a single generation. It is now one of the most common reasons a “previously fertile” couple walks in, bewildered. “We didn’t even try the first time,” they say. “Why is it so hard now?”

Part of the answer is the calendar. A generation ago, most couples finished their families in their twenties. Today a first baby often arrives at the age of 31 or 32 – after the degree, the

job, the EMI, the move to a rented flat in a city.

By the time life finally feels “ready” for a second child, the mother may be aged 36 or 38, and fertility, unfairly, does not wait for our life plans. Egg numbers and quality fall with every passing year; clinics in cities including Delhi/NCR, Bengaluru, Mumbai and others, have reported a sharp rise in women seeking help only after the age of 35.

But age is just one thread. In the years between the first and second child, bodies change. Weight creeps up. The thyroid quietly slips. As many as one in five Indian women now lives with Polyendocrine Metabolic Ovarian Syndrome (PMOS), which tends to worsen with time. A Caesarean section may have left adhesions; an old, untreated infection may have scarred a fallopian tube. And – this matters – the problem is very often on the man’s side. Sperm counts fall with weight, stress, smoking and even the polluted air so many of us breathe. Yet in my experience, Indian men will wait years longer than their wives before agreeing to a simple semen test, convinced that “we already have a child, so it can’t be me.”

Layered over all of this is something



Growing concern: Secondary infertility is the difficulty conceiving or carrying a pregnancy after you have already had a baby. GETTY IMAGES

newer: our phones. Social media has, in many ways, been a gift for fertility awareness. Couples now arrive far better informed than a decade ago; the taboo is finally cracking; brave women share IVF journeys that once would have been whispered about. But scroll through any feed and you also meet the other side – an unending stream of “Baby No. 2!” announcements, and picture-perfect siblings.

For a woman in her fourth month of trying, or recovering from a second miscarriage,

that scroll is a slow bruise. The comparison is relentless – and so is the family WhatsApp group where an aunt asks, yet again, when the “good news” is coming. I have also watched social media do harm the other way: glossy reels promising IVF “success in one cycle,” or home remedies that persuade a couple to delay proper testing by a year they cannot afford to lose.

Telling the truth

So what do I tell the couple crying in my room? First, that their pain is real and they are allowed to feel it. Wanting a sibling for the child you adore is not ingratitude; it is love asking

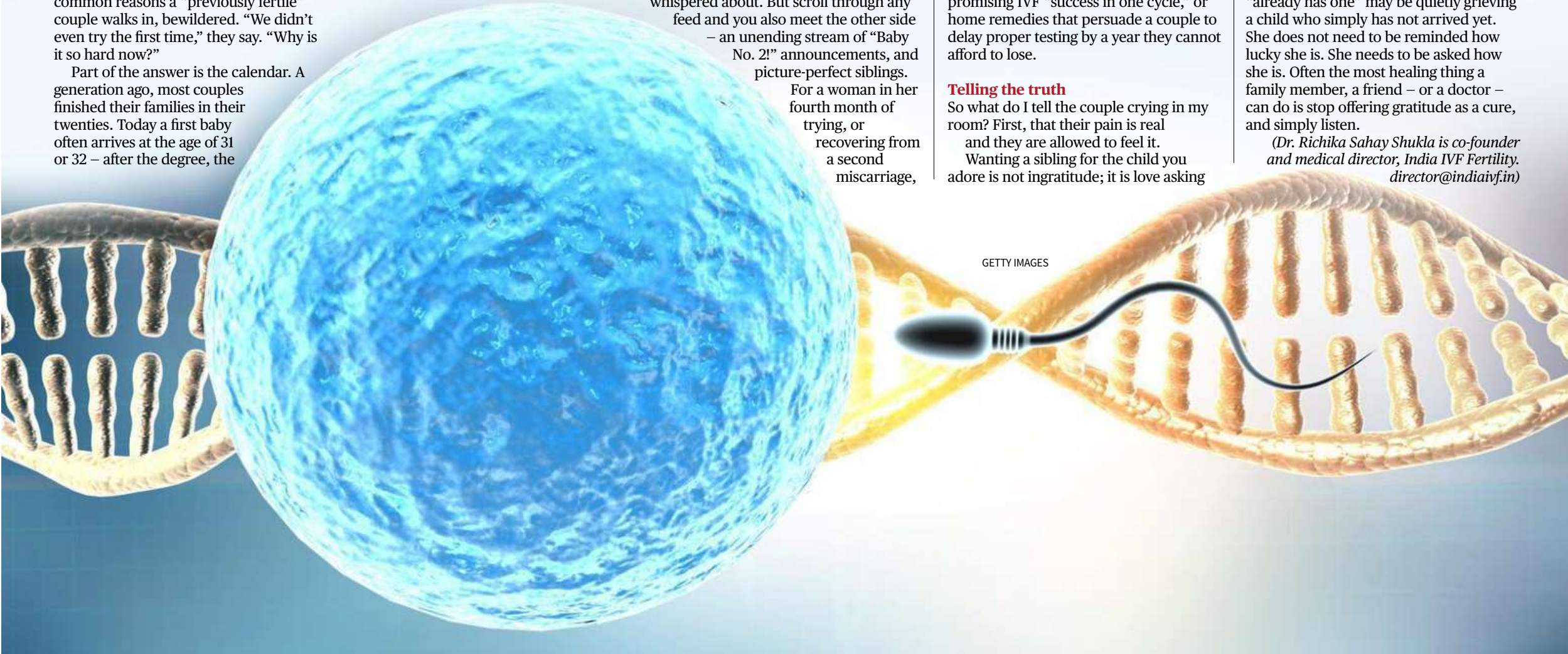
Egg numbers and quality fall with every passing year; clinics in cities including Delhi/National Capital Region, Bengaluru, Mumbai and others, have reported a sharp rise in women seeking help only after the age of 35

for a little more room. Second, that this is a medical condition, not a moral verdict – not a punishment, not *nazar*, not something they did wrong. Third, that timing matters. If a woman is under the age of 35 and has tried for a year, or over the age of 35 and has tried for six months, both partners – together – should be evaluated. Do not let the calendar run, out of politeness.

And I tell them the truth about hope, honestly. Modern fertility care helps a great many couples in exactly this situation, and IVF succeeds for many even in their late thirties and forties. But I will never promise a guaranteed outcome, and I would gently warn anyone against a clinic that does. What I can promise is a clear answer and a plan.

If there is one thing I wish more of us understood, it is this: the woman who “already has one” may be quietly grieving a child who simply has not arrived yet. She does not need to be reminded how lucky she is. She needs to be asked how she is. Often the most healing thing a family member, a friend – or a doctor – can do is stop offering gratitude as a cure, and simply listen.

(Dr. Richika Sahay Shukla is co-founder and medical director, India IVF Fertility. director@indiaivf.in)



Study to contain antimicrobial resistant neonatal sepsis begins in India

Ramya Kannan
CHENNAI

Striking at the heart of antimicrobial resistance, the international NeoSep 1 trial to evaluate life-saving antibiotic combinations for newborns with sepsis has expanded to India, with the first baby being recruited at the Jawaharlal Postgraduate Education Institute of Medical and Research (JIPMER) in Puducherry.

This was followed by recruiting an infant for the study in Pt. B.D. Sharma PGIMS in Rohtak. The next on the list is Lokmanya Tilak Municipal College and General Hospital, Mumbai. Globally, the study, sponsored by the GARDP Foundation in collaboration with the UCL Innovative Clinical Trials Unit; City St George's, University of London (SGUL), and Penta Foundation, is also underway in Vietnam and Pakistan, and will soon start in Malaysia, Bangladesh and Uganda.

According to a GARDP statement, NeoSep1 aims to enrol 3,000 newborns across Asia and Africa by the end of 2028. Earlier, newborns were enrolled in Ghana, Kenya and South Africa.

Life-threatening infection

Neonatal sepsis is a life-threatening bloodstream infection that occurs in babies under 90 days old, often affecting premature or low-birth-weight infants. It is categorised into early-onset (occurring within the first 72 hours of life) and late-onset (occurring up to 28-90 days), according to a book on neonatal sepsis, authored by Meenakshi Singh.

“With underdeveloped immune systems, newborns are especially prone to life-threatening sepsis,” Sally Ellis, Children’s Antibiotics Project Leader for



Addressing a big issue: Neonatal sepsis is a life-threatening bloodstream infection that occurs in babies under 90 days old, often affecting premature or low-birth-weight infants. AP

GARDP, told *The Hindu*, explaining the significance the NeoSep1 has in the context of growing antimicrobial resistance.

“Today, we stand at a tipping point. The antibiotics for newborns that we have relied on for decades are failing against resistant infections, in many hospital settings. This trial, led by GARDP and partners, is about giving neonatologists new tools, and giving babies with sepsis a fighting chance at life,” she adds.

Sepsis is the second most common cause of neonatal mortality, globally responsible for over one million deaths annually. In

India, neonatal sepsis remains a leading cause of neonatal mortality, contributing to approximately 30%-40% of all neonatal deaths despite advances in neonatal care, argues a recent paper ‘Neonatal Sepsis in India: Epidemiology, Risk Factors and Preventive Strategies from a Public Health Perspective’ in the *Journal of Clinical Neonatology*.

The author Ahmed Abdulaziz Almohammadi, writes “In India, neonatal sepsis accounts for an estimated 30%-40% of all neonatal deaths, translating to approximately 2,00,000-2,50,000



Today, we stand at a tipping point. The antibiotics for newborns that we have relied on for decades are failing against resistant infections, in many hospital settings. This trial, led by the GARDP and partners, is about giving neonatologists new tools, and giving babies with sepsis a fighting chance at life

SALLY ELLIS
Children’s Antibiotics Project Leader for GARDP

preventable deaths annually. Despite substantial reductions in under-five mortality over the past two decades, progress in reducing neonatal mortality has lagged, with sepsis representing a persistent and largely preventable cause of death.”

Divergence from global trends

It turns out that causative agents in India show a divergence from global trends. Dr. Almohammadi notes that the microbiological profile of neonatal sepsis in India differs substantially from that of high-income countries, with gram-negative organisms predominating in most Indian studies. *Klebsiella pneumoniae*, *Escherichia coli*, *Acinetobacter* species and *Pseudomonas aeruginosa* constitute the majority of bacterial isolates, often demonstrating multidrug resistance. Group B Streptococcus (GBS), which is the leading cause of neonatal sepsis in developed countries, accounts for only 2%-5% of cases in India.

This makes the NeoSep 1 critical – to evaluate and produce a profile that is India

specific, addressing the circumstances that can contribute to, or ameliorate the condition in India. It is pioneering the use of a Personalised Randomised Controlled Trial (PRACTical) design, which will evaluate and rank multiple antibiotic regimens for newborns with sepsis. This approach will help clinicians choose effective treatments best suited to their local context, GARDP spokespersons say.

The goal of the trial is to identify one or more safe, effective, and affordable treatments that can reduce the high number of newborn deaths caused by drug-resistant sepsis, especially in low- and middle-income countries. Part 1 of the NeoSep1 trial, conducted in South Africa and Kenya in 2023, assessed and validated the appropriate dose for fosfomycin and flomoxef for use in newborns, in combination with other antibiotics.

Nishad Plakkal, Principal Investigator of the NeoSep1 trial in India and Head of the Department of Neonatology at JIPMER, explains: “the study is a pragmatic trial and allows clinicians to make the diagnosis of sepsis as they normally would. However, to ensure the inclusion of infants with a high probability of infection, we use a sepsis severity score that we derived from an earlier global observational study (NeoOBS). Our microbiology team cultures the baby’s blood (and sometimes spinal fluid) to help identify the organism causing sepsis, typically within a day or two. They also identify antibiotic-resistant infections.”

Dr. Plakkal explains that the primary outcome, or the main question the study is designed to answer, is death within 28 days; while secondary outcomes will include death within 90 days, need for additional antibiotics, length of hospital stay, and re-admission.

(ramya.kannan@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Share of universities that participated in NIRF

55 in per cent. Only 55% universities participated in the government's NIRF rankings, while 56% of them have introduced the four-year undergraduate courses so far, according to the Centre's All India Survey on Higher Education report for 2023-24. The Ministry of Education on Wednesday released the reports of the AISHE for the years 2022-23 and 2023-24. PTI

Number of voters deleted in SIR draft electoral rolls

22 in lakh. Around 22 lakh voters have been left out of the draft electoral rolls in four States, where Phase 3 of the special intensive revision (SIR) of voter lists is under way. According to data made available in the public domain in the last few days by chief electoral officers of Mizoram, Odisha, Manipur and Sikkim, their combined voter base has shrunk by nearly 22 lakh. PTI

Number of ration card issuances to be expedited by Bihar CM

1 in crore. Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday directed officials to expedite the issuance of one crore new ration cards to eligible beneficiaries across the State. Union Consumer Affairs and Public Distribution Minister Pralhad Joshi and the CM chaired a comprehensive review meeting here to assess various departmental schemes and the functioning of PDS in the State. PTI

Routes disrupted by heavy rain in Uttarakhand

107 Continuous rainfall over the past 24 hours across Uttarakhand has raised river water levels and triggered landslides in hilly areas, disrupting traffic on 107 routes across the State. The Meteorological Department has issued a 'Red Alert' for very heavy rainfall in seven districts, including Dehradun, and an 'Orange Alert' for the remaining districts for Thursday. PTI

Illegal coal recovered by CISF in West Bengal, Jharkhand

428 in metric tonnes. The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) personnel recovered more than 428 metric tonnes of coal during a five-day special operation to check the pilferage and theft of the fossil fuel from mines in Jharkhand and West Bengal, officials said on Thursday. PTI
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Why is the Centre revising the NFSA?

Why has the Centre proposed changing AAY foodgrain entitlements? How will the proposed amendment affect households? Why are Tamil Nadu and Kerala opposing? Could the amendment widen regional disparities in foodgrain allocation?

EXPLAINER

T. Ramakrishnan

The story so far:

In July 6, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay urged the Centre to retain the present provision of 35 kg of foodgrains per household per month under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) meant for the poorest of the poor, and not to make it a per capita system. The next day, the CPI(M) Polit Bureau voiced its concern and demanded that the proposed amendment to the entitlement criteria be dropped. About 10 days ago, immediately after the Union government made public its plan to amend the National Food Security Act (NFSA), Kerala's Food Minister Anoop Jacob expressed reservations over the move.

What is the amendment mooted?

On June 24, the Union Food and Public Distribution (F&PD) Department, while publishing a draft amendment Bill to the NFSA, said every person belonging to AAY households would be entitled to seven kg of foodgrains per month, subject to a maximum of 35 kg per household per month. At present, the entitlement is for the entire household with a ceiling of 35 kg per month. The proposed amendment covers the first proviso to sub-section (1) of Section 3 (Right to receive foodgrains at subsidised prices by persons belonging to eligible households) of the Act. The public can comment on the amendments till July 13 and send their views by email to suneel.sachdeva@nic.in and saurabhomar.edu@gov.in.

Why is the change being proposed?

The existing household-based entitlement, though intended as a protective measure for the most vulnerable families, results in significant inequities depending upon the size of the household, according to the F&PD Department. Smaller households receive a higher per-capita entitlement, whereas larger households receive a lower per-capita entitlement, which may fall below the entitlement available to priority households.

The aim and purpose are to remove intra-category inequities, provide for more rational foodgrain allocation, and better align entitlements with nutritional requirements, a note prepared by the department said.

However, the proposed amendment does not seek to address the inclusion of ineligible persons as beneficiaries, a problem that persists at the State level.

What is the story behind the two southern States' opposition?

It is not for the first time that the two States are articulating their opposition to matters concerning the food policy, as their contemporary political history has an important ingredient – the politics of food. Kerala, which has a long history of the public distribution system (PDS) dating back to the now-abolished princely State of Travancore, introduced informal food distribution mechanisms to mitigate the food shortage of the poor and vulnerable, and was perhaps the first to launch a formal PDS in 1962, three years before the establishment of the Food Corporation of India (FCI). At least on two occasions – 1952 and 1967 – Tamil Nadu saw political upsets, the incumbent regime getting reduced to a minority in 1952 and being shown the door (in 1967). The reason was that the governments of

Grains of debate

The Centre's proposed amendment to the National Food Security Act has triggered concerns that foodgrain allocations under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana could fall for many households in the southern States



Table 1: AAY coverage, beneficiaries and foodgrain allocation

State	Ceiling of AAY households (lakhs)	AAY coverage		Allocation of foodgrains** for 2026-27 (in tonnes)
		No. of AAY households (in lakh)	No. of persons (in lakh)	
Andhra Pradesh	9.09	8.48	22.48	3,81,557
Karnataka	12	10.3	42.72	4,60,740
Kerala	5.96	5.93	18.53	2,50,236
Tamil Nadu	18.65	18.57	62.21	7,82,771
Telangana	6.49	5.64	15.66	2,38,074
Puducherry* (U.T.)	0.32	0.24	0.77	0*
Share of the South	52.51	49.16	162.37	21,13,378
All India	250	217.01	777.41	99,33,042

Source: Foodgrain bulletin for May 2026, Department of Food and Public Distribution, Government of India

*As Puducherry follows the concept of direct benefit transfer, no allocation has been made.

** foodgrains - rice, wheat and coarse grains

Fine balance: The aim and purpose of the amendment are to remove intra-category inequities, provide for more rational foodgrain allocation, and better align entitlements with nutritional requirements. M. SRINATH

Table 2: Off-take and distribution in the Southern States

How the South fared during the current financial year up to the month of May 2026 (tonnes)

State	Allocation	Off take (drawal)	Distributed
Andhra Pradesh	63,593	63,593	57,837
Karnataka	76,790	57,316	35,003
Kerala	41,706	39,812	20,458
Tamil Nadu	1,30,462	1,90,135	1,21,709
Telangana	39,679	59,519	38,893
Share of the South	3,52,230	4,10,375	2,73,900
All India	16,55,505	17,24,185	13,75,621

the periods in question were not being swift in handling the rice shortage. Since 1967, successive Chief Ministers of the State have been cautious in taking decisions with regard to the subject of rice.

It was no wonder that the two States were vociferous in their stand in the run-up to the formulation of the NFSA. Though the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) took charge in 2011 in Kerala, the government did not agree to the implementation of the 2013 law – an Act of Parliament – despite the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance regime at the Centre pushing the legislation. The main reservation it had was that the NFSA would lead to the removal of a “large number of poor families” from the list of beneficiaries and put an “enormous financial burden” on the State. However, the then Chief Minister, Oommen Chandy, at one point in time, committed himself to the enforcement of the law in his State, though it was left to his successor, Pinarayi Vijayan, to take the formal decision.

In Tamil Nadu, Jayalalithaa, as Chief Minister, virulently opposed the law because immediately after she came to power in May 2011, her government started the distribution of rice, free to all the ration cardholders, regardless of their economic status. She had criticised the government for stating that those who would be left out of the NFSA would not

‘The existing household-based entitlement, though intended as a protective measure for the most vulnerable families, results in significant inequities depending upon the size of the household’

be eligible to receive free rice. Eventually, she extracted a major concession from the Union government that the existing allocations, as they stood in 2013, for all the States would be legally safeguarded.

Hence, it was no surprise that the two southern neighbours joined the rest of the country in November 2016 in implementing the law.

Why are Tamil Nadu and Kerala opposing the amendment to NFSA?

Explaining how Kerala would be affected by the latest move, Mr. Jacob has pointed out that States such as his, characterised by nuclear families, will be at a disadvantage as there will be a reduction in the quantity of free foodgrains for families with fewer than five members. He has recalled that even in 2013, when the law took effect, his State took the stand that the AAY cardholders deserved “special consideration,” a position that it continues. “As a consumption State, any cut in Kerala's allocation is a matter of concern,” Mr. Jacob stated.

Mr. Vijay, who referred in his letter to Mr. Modi about how the amendment

would cause a fall in the monthly allocation of foodgrains from 65,261 tonnes to 42,040 tonnes, stated that the number of AAY cardholders below the family size of five members is 15.75 lakh (out of a total of 18.64 lakhs), covering 58.51 lakh beneficiaries (total: 69.27 lakhs). “Rice provided to the AAY cardholders is a staple ingredient of all three meals of the day and cannot be substituted with any other commodity from the open market, resulting in substantial out of pocket expenses,” he said.

Besides, Anuradha Talwar, a functionary of the Right to Food Campaign, said that the amendment would bring a “North-South divide” in foodgrain allocation, as families in northern States would get higher allocations as their average family size was bigger than that of the southern States.

What is the way forward?

Ideally, such a change should have been subjected to greater public scrutiny to arrive at a consensus. However, T. Sadagopan, president, Tamil Nadu Progressive Consumer Centre and veteran activist who served on the State government's panels on food, suggests that the Centre chalk out a middle path by making the allocation of 30 kg per family, irrespective of family members. This would help the Union government to cut down its subsidy bill.

THE GIST

▼ The Centre has proposed amending the NFSA to change AAY foodgrain entitlements from a household-based system to a per capita allocation of 7 kg per person, subject to a maximum of 35 kg per household, to address inequities in the existing system.

▼ Tamil Nadu and Kerala have opposed the proposal, arguing that it will reduce foodgrain allocations for households with fewer than five members and increase the burden on poor families, particularly in States with predominantly nuclear families.

▼ While the Centre says the amendment will make foodgrain distribution more equitable, critics warn it could widen regional disparities, and some have suggested a middle path of a fixed 30 kg allocation per household.

Marathi and the long politics behind the language question

Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* officially made its premiere this week, with critics giving it rave reviews. A quiz on ancient Greek literature